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Return to an Inner Utopia

In what was to become a celebrated act in Chinese literary history, Su Shi began systematically composing “matching Tao” (*he Tao* 和陶) poems in the spring of 1095, during his period of exile in Huizhou. This project of 109 poems was completed when he was further exiled to Danzhou. It was issued in four fascicles, shortly after his return to the mainland in 1100.¹ Inspired by and following the rhyming patterns of the poetry of Tao Qian, these poems contributed to the making (and remaking) of the images of both poets, as well as a return to simplicity in Chinese lyrical aesthetics.²

Thus far, scholarship has focused on the significance of Su Shi’s agency in Tao Qian’s canonisation. His image was transformed through Su’s criticism and emulation: Tao came to be viewed as a spontaneous Man of the Way and not just an eccentric medieval recluse and hearty drinker.³ In other words, Tao Qian’s ‘spontaneity’ was only created retrospectively in lament over its loss. The unattainability of the ideal is part and parcel of its worth.

In this chapter, I will further examine what Su Shi’s practice meant for Su Shi himself. I argue that Su Shi’s active transformation of and identification with Tao Qian’s image were driven by the purpose of overcoming the tyranny of despair, deprivation and mortality. The apparent serenity of the “matching Tao” poems was therefore fundamentally paradoxical, a result of self-persuasion. As Ronald Egan has noted, Su deliberately sought to avoid sorrow and self-pity in exile, even though in his poems “one finds a degree of insistence upon contentment in the new surroundings that is unexampled in Tao’s originals.”⁴ Such insistence betrayed the forced nature of their analogy, which was not lost on Su’s contemporaries. As Su Che remarked in the preface to his

1 This anthology was highly popular in the Song and was repeatedly printed in various editions. The earliest existing wood-block print, preserved in the National Taiwan Library, was issued at the end of the Northern Song in Huangzhou; see Liu Shangrong 劉尚榮, *Su Shi zhuzuo banben luncong* 蘇軾著作版本論叢 (Chengdu: Bashu shushe, 1988), 24–33.

2 For further information on the rising aesthetic category of *pingdan*, related especially to Tao Qian’s poetry, see Swartz, *Reading Tao*, 186–200.

3 For recent examples, see Tian, *Tao Yuanming and Manuscript Culture*, 4–6, 31–44, and *passim*; Swartz, *Reading Tao*, 87–90, 200–4, 210–11; Ashmore, Robert, *The Transport of Reading: Text and Understanding in the World of Tao Qian (365–427)* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Asia Center, 2010), 245–6.

4 Egan, *Word, Image, and Deed*, 234.

elder brother's collected "matching Tao" poems, Tao abruptly resigned from office for a trivial slight, but Su Shi remained an official despite malicious defamation, prosecution and multiple exiles.⁵ The external 'traces' of their life trajectories were thus glaringly different. To justify his identification, Su defined his 'return' (*gui* 歸) as returning to an inner state of spontaneity, unconditioned by external contingencies. Tao's resignation was thus understood as a consequence of his natural disposition – just like Su's exile, an inevitable outcome of his unyielding character. In this regard, both not only 'returned' to living a spontaneous life in nature, but also chanced their return in seemingly different, but equally natural, fashion. Their difference was thus not a matter of choice (Tao) versus force (Su), but solely in that Tao's return was earlier, more resolute and more thorough. In this sense, Su should and could have emulated this paragon of disengagement to complete his own course of return.

Yet, another irony appears to have eluded Su Shi. When he sought to experience his exile through Tao's poetry, the wild southern landscape lost its immediacy and was instead fashioned after the poetic representation of Tao's orderly farmstead below Mt Lu (in modern Jiangxi Province). In other words, Su Shi metaphorically domesticated the Far South to be part of China's heartland. During the Northern Song, Huizhou (and especially Danzhou) signified the southern-most periphery of Chinese civilisation. Su's account of the local Dan 蜚 and Li 黎 people betrayed a strong Han-ethnocentric perspective. Solitude, cultural alienation and material deprivation often haunted the ageing poet. Matching Tao's farmstead poetry was therefore a means to distance and aestheticise his immediate surroundings, as well as transform them into a reflection of another, much different, literary landscape. In this sense, Su's return into nature was both his retreat from nature in its raw, undomesticated state, and his entry into a cultural landscape furnished with familiar ethical paradigms. Meanwhile, as an exile, he also discovered a pattern of disengagement in Tao's work which allowed him to voice political dissent. His sense of alienation from the immediate material nature, as well as from the distant political centre, together with his deepening interest in Daoist alchemy, contributed to his rediscovery of Peach Blossom Spring. It was no longer a secret corner isolated from the external world, as Tao Qian's original account had depicted,⁶ but an inner utopia with the features of an alchemist's grotto heaven. At last, as his rewriting of Tao's rhyme-prose "Return!" (*Guifulai xi ci* 歸去來兮辭)

5 See Su Che, "Zizhan he Tao Yuanming shiji yin" 子瞻和陶淵明詩集引, *Su Che ji, houji* 21.1110–11 (also commonly known as "Dongpo xiansheng he Tao Yuanming shi yin" 東坡先生和陶淵明詩引), as quoted in *SSSJ*, 35.1882–3.

6 See Tao Qian, "Taohuayuan ji bing shi" 桃花源記并詩, *TYM*, 6.479–80.

shows, his journey of no-return into the ever-farther south was transformed into a journey of returning 'home' – that is, an inner realm of spontaneity.

Literary Friendship with an Ancient

As Robert Ashmore has noted, Tao Qian's reception is unique, comparable only to that of Qu Yuan 屈原 (c. 343–c. 277 BCE), in that his collection was "continuously augmented by successive generations of reader-authors who felt incited to commemorate the ancestor poet by composing new poems in the ancestor's voice".⁷ This self-conscious emulation and identification formed a diachronic circle of literary friendship, the members of which not only shared a kindred 'ambition' (*zhi* 志),⁸ but literally spoke in one harmonised voice.

Su Shi was a poet with his own unique voice. His disposition towards erudite exposition, eloquent persuasion, hyperbole and the fantastical – often faulted by friends and foes as being either unrestrained⁹ or utterly 'crafty' and ornamented¹⁰ – was quite unlike Tao Qian's poetry of understatement. Even in his "matching Tao" poems, Su Shi, in the words of the Qing commentator Ji Yun 紀昀 (1727–1805), "gathered his talents tight to approximate Tao, but from time to time revealed his true colours" 斂才就陶、亦時時自露本色.¹¹ Often Su Shi's poems were found to be more clever, skilful and dramatic than Tao's originals. As the poet and critic Yuan Haowen remarked: "Though Dongpo matched the poetry of Tao, the aura and appearance [of his poems] are simply that of Dongpo." 東坡和陶、氣象祇是東坡.¹² Despite their obvious difference, however, Su Shi's later poetry did change under the influence of Tao. It became more understated, at times deliberately so. As discussed in Chapter Two, for Su Shi the aesthetic appearance of 'the even and the plain' required the highest level of craftsmanship. To emulate Tao was to 'return to Tao', namely stylistic minimalism by an author capable of extreme sophistication.

7 Ashmore, *Transport of Reading*, 244.

8 As noted in *Mencius*, 5A.4, readers of the *Odes* should "deploy their minds to encounter the [ancient poet's] ambition" 以意逆志.

9 Huang Tingjian, for instance, cautioned his nephew not to learn from Su Shi's "being fond of abusing" (*haoma* 好罵); see "Da Hong Jufu shu", 474.

10 As represented by Zhu Xi's repeated criticism; see, e.g., *Zhuzi quanshu* 朱子全書, ed. Zhu Jieren 朱傑人 (Shanghai: Shanghai guji chubanshe & Hefei: Anhui jiaoyu chubanshe, 2002), vol. 18, *yulei* 語類, 139.4300, 4302, 4305–6, 4308, 4314.

11 Quoted in the commentary to "He Tao 'Yinjiu ershishou'" 和陶飲酒二十首, no. 20, *SSSJ*, 35.1892.

12 Yuan Haowen, "Ba Dongpo 'Yinjiushi' hou" 跋東坡飲酒詩後, quoted in *SSSJ*, 35.1891.

Yet Su's emulation was not only driven by the literary value of Tao's poetry, but equally, if not more, by his admiration of and identification with Tao's poetic persona. He empathised with Tao's 'weakness', which was a "stubborn nature and unwieldy endowment, often in contradiction with worldly things" 性剛才拙與物多忤.¹³ He argued that his remaining in office was but a 'guise' (*ji* 跡, literally 'trace' or 'footprint') and not true evidence with which to judge a character.¹⁴ Despite their different 'guises', Su intimated that he and Tao shared the same unyielding honesty which dictated their choices in life.

In the case of Su Shi, however, such 'choices' were hardly voluntary: his repeated periods of exile were the consequences of his failures to navigate the treacherous cycles of factional strife (between 'reformers' [*xindang* 新黨] and 'conservatives' [*jiudang* 舊黨]), which defined the Northern Song political landscape. Yet, by hinting at his "stubborn nature", Su Shi implied that his suffering was not just due to the forces of fate, but also – perhaps even more so – due to his character. Assuming a certain responsibility for his suffering endowed him with power and agency. Only by claiming this power of choice did Su Shi's magic escape from exile into an inner utopia of freedom become possible. Adversity became opportunity. Material deprivation was understood as the precondition of his Daoist diet, therefore facilitating his pursuit of longevity. Likewise, social isolation helped him select friends from the large repertoire of ancient worthies. Tao Qian and Ge Hong, the latter reportedly became an immortal on Mt Luofu in Huizhou, were summoned to join a new triad of 'Three Gentlemen' (*sanshi* 三士).¹⁵ Holding their hands, he shall "Return! Oh return!" 歸哉復歸哉.¹⁶ The singular direction of returning home suggests teleology. He was not a victim of capricious fate but its master, able to maintain a stable and steady course of return through ups and downs, towards a primordial state of simplicity and spontaneity.

Despite this picture implying a predesigned direction, such a return in both lifestyle and literary expression could hardly be foreseen in Su Shi's previous writing. His first explicit attempt to emulate Tao Qian was in his "Eight Poems of the East Slope" (Dongpo bashou 東坡八首), written in 1081 during his exile

13 Su Che, "Zizhan he Tao Yuanming shiji yin", in *Su Che ji, houji* 21.1110–11.

14 This line, though found in Su Che's preface, was perhaps written by Su Shi himself. According to a Song author (who had a chance to see the manuscript of the preface at the home of Su Che's third son, Su Xun 蘇遜), Su Che's original preface claimed that Tao Qian was, in effect, a lesser talent, and that Su Shi's admiration showed his humility in appreciating every virtue in others. Su Shi revised this passage to its present, more reverent form. See Fei Gun 費袞, *Liangxi manzhi* 梁溪漫志 (Shanghai: Shanghai shudian, 1999), 4.1–2.

15 See Su Shi, "He Tao 'Du Shanhaijing'" 和陶讀山海經, no. 1, *SSSJ*, 39.2130.

16 Ibid., no. 13, *SSSJ*, 39.2136.

in Huangzhou, to commemorate his farming experience.¹⁷ Eleven years later, Su Shi, now the Magistrate of Yangzhou 揚州, wrote twenty poems, each matching a piece in Tao Qian's poetic series entitled "Drinking" (Yinjiu 飲酒).¹⁸ He declared that he had developed a penchant for staying tipsy – or rather, constantly holding a half-empty wine cup while drinking sparingly due to his low tolerance of alcohol. This earliest instance of matching Tao's poems seemed to be a singular act, indicating no systematic agenda; were it not for Su's later exiles, it seemed unlikely to be resumed. According to Su Shi, in the third month of 1095, one day after an excursion to a waterfall in the mountains of Huizhou, he was inspired by his son's recital of Tao Qian's "Return to My Garden and Fields" (Gui yuantianju 歸園田居), and was determined to undertake a project of matching the entire catalogue of Tao's work.¹⁹ Only through this last systematic enterprise were his earlier sporadic emulations given a teleological perspective, portending a disposition that was yet to be fully developed. His last periods of exile were therefore also presented as necessary, both as a result of his natural disposition and as a precondition to complete his 'return'.

With these poems, Su Shi initiated a sub-genre in Chinese poetry called *zhuihe* 追和, or 'matching [an ancient poet's poems] in retrospect'. As he declared to Su Che:

Poets of earlier times had 'Imitating the Old' poems but had never matched the poems of an ancient author. Retrospectively matching the poetry of an ancient author begins with Dongpo!

古之詩人有擬古之作矣，未有追和古人者也。追和古人，則始於東坡！²⁰

To be precise, poets before Su Shi did occasionally write poems matching those of the ancients.²¹ Unlike Su Shi's, however, these were isolated random acts

17 Su Shi, "Dongpo bashou", *SSSJ*, 21.1079–84.

18 See Su Shi, "He Tao 'Yinjiu ershishou' bing xu" 和陶飲酒二十首并敘, *SSSJ*, 35.1881–92.

19 See Su Shi, "He Tao 'Gui yuantianju liushou' bing yin" 和陶歸園田居六首并引, *SSSJ*, 39.2103–4. Su Guo 蘇過 (1072–1123) was the only son who followed Su Shi to Huizhou and then Danzhou.

20 See Su Che, "Zizhan he Tao Yuanming shiji yin", *Su Che ji, houji* 21.1110–11.

21 For instance, Li He 李賀, "Zhuihe Liu Yun" 追和柳惲, *QTS*, 390.4395, "Zhuihe He Xie 'Tongque ji'" 追和何謝銅雀妓, *QTS*, 392.4412; Li Deyu 李德裕, "Zhuihe taishi Yan gong tong Qingyuan daoshi you Huqiusi" 追和太師顏公同清遠道士遊虎丘寺, *QTS*, 475-5392; Pi Rixiu 皮日休, "Zhuihe Huqiusi Qingyuan daoshi shi" 追和虎丘寺清遠道士詩, *QTS*, 609.7029, "Zhuihe Youdujun ciyun ershou" 追和幽獨君次韻二首, *QTS*, 609.7030;

that never reached his scale or degree of systematic self-identification. Poetic exchange was first initiated in the Six Dynasties.²² It was a token of friendship, publically displayed, beckoning the whole republic of letters, as well as later readers, to bear witness. Since Bo Juyi and Yuan Zhen 元稹 (779–831), whose close friendship and extensive exchange of poetry made them known as Yuan-Bo 元白 (also the name for their style),²³ poetic exchange was used by poets to promote their similar styles, such as Ou-Mei 歐梅 (Ouyang Xiu and Mei Yaochen 梅堯臣 [1002–1060]) and Su-Huang 蘇黃 (Su Shi and Huang Tingjian). Poetic exchange was even deliberately exploited by otherwise obscure figures to form paired names or perceived literary groups, such as Pi-Lu 皮陸 (Pi Rixiu 皮日休 [c. 834/839–after 902] and Lu Guimeng 陸龜蒙 [?–881]) and the ‘Nine Monks’ in Early Song. Su Shi’s extensive matching of the poetry of Tao Qian, therefore, could be placed in this tradition as a deliberate effort to create a literary equal. Unlike in the other cases, which had real-life liaisons prior to literary exchanges, Su Shi essentially reversed the primacy and fashioned a literary friendship with Tao Qian through his one-way poetic exchange.

Moreover, exchange poetry was essentially social in nature and was often composed on occasions of genteel gatherings as a learned pastime. By the Northern Song, it was practised in every stratum of literary society.²⁴ The percentage of ‘matching poems’ among one’s compositions during a certain period, if faithfully preserved, served as a record and index of one’s social activeness. Around one-third of Su Shi’s extant poems were composed explicitly

Lu Guimeng 陸龜蒙, “Ci zhuihe Qingyuan daoshi shiyun bing xu” 次追和清遠道士詩韻並序, *QTS*, 617.7114, “Ci Youdujun yun” 次幽獨君韻, *QTS*, 619.7128; etc. Such practices, however, were rare, whimsical and not influential. There are also a few ‘matching Tao’ poems attributed to Tang Yanqian 唐彥謙 (*jinshi* 861), now collected in *QTS* (671.7677). But scholars have pointed out that they were composed by the Yuan poet Dai Biaoyuan 戴表元 (1244–1310). See Wang Zhaopeng 王兆鵬, “Tang Yanqian sishishou yanshi zhengwei” 唐彥謙四十首贗詩證偽, *Zhonghua wenshi luncong* 中華文史論叢 (1993), 52: 226–44.

22 For a study on the transformation of forms of poetic exchange from the Six Dynasties through the Tang, see Zhao Yiwu 趙以武, *Changhe shi yanjiu* 唱和詩研究 (Lanzhou: Gansu wenhua chubanshe, 1997).

23 For the study on their exchange poetry, see Anna M. Shields, “Remembering When: the Uses of Nostalgia in the Poetry of Bai Juyi and Yuan Zhen”, *Harvard Journal of Asiatic Studies* 66.2 (2006): 321–61.

24 By focusing on the exchanges in the group around Ouyang and Mei, Colin S.C. Hawes even proposes that the main justification for writing poems during the Northern Song was “to develop and sustain human relationships through the regular exchange of poems with friends and acquaintances”. See Hawes, *The Social Circulation of Poetry in Mid-Northern Song* (Albany: SUNY, 2005), 3.

as matching poetry, with verbs like *he* 和 ('harmonise with'), *chou* 酬 ('reciprocate') or *da* 答 ('respond to') in the title. The percentage of exchange poems with his contemporaries was highest while he was in the capital, and lowest during his three periods of exile. There, the reading and matching of Tao Qian's poetry compensated for the lack of a literary society.

By methodically going through the entire corpus of Tao, Su Shi beckoned the camaraderie of an ancient kindred spirit, a gesture that served an ideological purpose. No one could or would match a contemporary poet's *oeuvre* in its entirety. In comparison, Su's matching of Tao's entire corpus elevated their relationship from that of friendship to, in Wendy Swartz's words, "virtual identification".²⁵ While poetic exchanges with a contemporary could often be obligated by decorum within an immediate setting, matching an ancient author was a purely voluntary choice, one that broke free from the limits of time and space. Such a choice was thus invested with the significance of identifying a role model whose literary merit and moral stature were objects of emulation.

Su Shi's admiration played a crucial role in Tao Qian's canonisation; a process that began in the Tang and culminated in the Song. In her study on Tao's reception history, Xiaofei Tian discussed how Su Shi was dissatisfied with the word "gaze" (*wang* 望) in Tao's "Drinking, No. 5". He replaced it with "see" (*jian* 見), so as to dissolve the intentionality implied by "gaze" and render Tao's behaviour completely spontaneous.²⁶ Similarly, Wendy Swartz observed how Su Shi, deliberately or not, misinterpreted Tao's poems to serve his argument that Tao had a genuine understanding of the Way (therefore differing in opinion from many Tang and Song critics).²⁷ Thus, when Su Shi identified himself with 'Tao Qian', he was actually identifying with an icon of his own making. This was a figure whose unconventional behaviour was not driven by whimsical impulse, but rather sustained by a tenacious adherence to the ideal of spontaneity. At the end of this canonisation process, Tao emerged no longer as an eccentric hovering on the margins of literary history, but as a "moral hero" whose behaviour was consistently guided by the Way.²⁸ By matching Tao's poems, Su Shi intimated that his own case was similar.

25 See Swartz, *Reading Tao*, 200–1.

26 Tian, *Tao Yuanming and Manuscript Culture*, 31–2.

27 Swartz, *Reading Tao*, 120–1.

28 For the "moral hero" and the Confucian ideal of reclusion, see Berkowitz, *Patterns of Disengagement*, 21. On Tao Qian's transformation into such a hero and the role Su Shi played, see Swartz, *Reading Tao*, 55, 73, 89–90.

A Metaphorical Landscape

The semi-barbaric Far South posed physical and existential challenges to Su Shi. He needed to adapt to deprivation, as well as to an alien ethnic culture. This was especially the case in Hainan: an island divided from the mainland by a broad surging strait, with its still-rudimentary agriculture. As Kathleen Tomlonovic has observed:

In crossing the natural barrier of water, Su Shi had passed over a cultural barrier as well. Although the island was under the jurisdiction of the Song court, which had designed policies for subduing the inhabitants, the area, particularly the interior, remained the domain of the native peoples.²⁹

Or as James Hargett pithily puts it, Hainan in the Northern Song was “the ultimate place of banishment”.³⁰ Living in the semi-barbaric inland of Hainan, Su Shi, one of the most learned men of the empire, was an oddity. To cope with his deep feeling of dislocation, Su Shi had to assimilate the foreign into his own system of meaning. He did this by poetically transforming the wilds that surrounded him, conforming them to the map of Tao Qian’s cultivated ‘garden and fields’. The culturally distinctive natives were assorted into various archetypes familiar in a poetic countryside. Yet, Su Shi’s own assumed roles were fluid and varied with the context. At times he represented himself as being completely integrated into this wild landscape; at other times, however, he adamantly adhered to his political and cultural identity, and played the role of a civilising force.

Modern academic literature often celebrates Su’s later exile poetry as evidence of his genuine love of nature and of ‘the folk’. Even though James Hargett remarked that the general praise of Su Shi’s propensity to “turn disaster into optimism” was too simplistic and ignored the phases of Su Shi coping with adversity, he nevertheless took Su’s optimism, his ‘friendship’ with the common Hainan locals, and his ‘identification’ with Tao Qian literally.³¹ As I will argue in this (and, in another way, also in the next) chapter, despite Su’s repeated invocation of ‘return’, doubts remain about how thorough or ‘natural’ his ‘return’ into the southern landscape was. About half of his poetry in Hui-

29 Kathleen M. Tomlonovic, “Poetry of Exile and Return: A Study of Su Shi” (PhD diss., University of Washington, 1989), 169.

30 James M. Hargett, “Clearing the Apertures and Getting in Tune: The Hainan Exile of Su Shi (1037–1101)”, *Journal of Song-Yuan Studies* (2000), 30: 144.

31 *Ibid.*, 163–4.

zhou and Danzhou was written to match Tao's. This fact poses the uneasy question of how much Su Shi allowed his immediate experience of nature to flow into words, if, to him, the entire landscape was an echo of Tao Qian's poetry.

Indeed, it is questionable as to whether any 'garden and fields' poetry can faithfully represent the unmediated countryside, given the fact that such poetry must employ literary skills, exist in a cultural system of reference, and acquire its significance through presenting an alternative space to the urban centre. Tao Qian's countryside was already populated by conventions and archetypes that were formed in the eremitic tradition before him. In comparison, Su Shi's countryside is even more metaphorical and idealised, at times so utopic that its rural residents are all moral ideals incarnate. This feature is explicit in Su's first "matching Tao" poem written in Huizhou, in response to Tao's "Returning to My Garden and Fields".³² The opening verse in Tao's series celebrates his return after thirty (or thirteen) years of service.³³ Of the ten couplets, eight use strict parallelism, imposing order onto the actual landscape

32 Tao's original consists of five poems, but Su Shi's matching series has six. The collection of Tao in Su's possession must have mistakenly included a sixth poem that was an imitation poem by Jiang Yan 江淹 (444–505), titled "Tao Zhengjun tianju" 陶徵君田居, in a series of thirty "Zatishi" 雜體詩; see Hu Zhiji 胡之驥, *Jiang Wentong ji huizhu* 江文通集彙註 (Beijing: Zhonghua shuju, 1984), 4.156–7. This imitation poem was not infrequently included in early editions of Tao's poetry.

33 Whether Tao's original fourth line was "Away I had been from home for thirty years" (*yiqu sanshi nian* 一去三十年) or "thirteen years" (*shisan nian* 十三年) is not just a question of textual variants, it is also associated with the broader picture of Tao's chronology, biography and the traditionally quintessential question on whether he was so loyal to the Jin Dynasty that he refused to serve under the Song (and even purportedly refused to use its reign names). Tao Qian's bureaucratic career had many obscurities. Yuan Xingpei's latest study supports the argument that he did serve under the Song. According to Yuan, Tao Qian held some short bureaucratic posts in his twenties. He lived idly until joining the military government of Huan Xuan 桓玄 (369–404) in 398, aiding the latter's rebellion against the Jin Dynasty. He stayed in service until the winter of 401, when his mother died and he returned home for the three-year ritual mourning period. Huan Xuan was defeated and killed by Liu Yu 劉裕 (363–422; r. 420–22), the would-be founder of the Liu Song Dynasty (420–479). Tao Qian then joined Liu Yu's military government in 404, became the Magistrate of Pengze County in 405, and resigned after some eighty days. See Yuan Xingpei, "Tao Qian nianpu jianbian" 陶淵明年譜簡編, *TYM*, 849–58. Clearly, if this poem commemorates his returning home after roughly three decades of desultory civil service, it should have been written after his final return in 405. "Thirteen" is likely a variant created to obliterate Tao's service under Liu Yu, which would have enraged some later readers as it was a betrayal of his former patron.

and creating a sense of regularity associated with farmstead life. In Su Shi's matching poem, strict parallelism is similarly used in the first four couplets:

環州多白水	Surrounding this prefecture, many white waters;
際海皆蒼山	hemming the coast, all dark hills.
以彼無盡景	By virtue of this infinite landscape,
寓我有限年	let me lodge here for my finite years!
東家著孔丘	The neighbour to the east houses Kong Qiu;
西家著顏淵	the neighbour to the west houses Yan Yuan!
市爲不二價	The merchants always set an honest price;
農爲不爭田	the farmers never fight over their fields. ³⁴

The “infinite landscape”, of rapid waters and dark mountains, suggests a sublime nature of black and white – the ‘colours’ in a literati landscape painting. Using Tao's closing-in perspective and orderly depiction, Su turns the wilderness into a protective force, benignly “surrounding” and “hemming in” the human domain where the poet could reside. In this small utopian society, not only are the residents in Su's elite neighbourhood Confucian sages, but even the merchants and farmers are paragons of decency. In this idyllic vision, Hui-zhou appears to be no longer a wild place on the periphery of Chinese civilisation, but a privileged heartland that represents natural order, civil harmony and moral perfection.

Su Shi's matching poems often downplay the elements of fear and anxiety in Tao Qian's originals, further creating a sense of smooth reconciliation with nature. The following couplet by Tao betrays a tangible fear of idling away a life in insignificance, symbolised by natural forces preying on his harvest:

常恐霜霰至	The arrival of frost and sleet is my constant fear,
零落同草莽	lest my crops fall prey, like grasses grown in the wilderness. ³⁵

In Su Shi's matching couplet, nature itself imposes the principle of order and is the real author of regulated and cultivated poetic lines:

春江有佳句	The spring river contains marvellous lines of poetry;
我醉墮渺莽	in my drunkenness they fall into the vast nebulousity. ³⁶

34 Su Shi, “He Tao ‘Gui yuantianju’ liushou” 和陶歸園田居六首, no. 1, SSSJ, 39.2104.

35 Tao Qian, “Gui yuantianju”, no. 2, TYM, 2.83.

36 Su Shi, “He Tao ‘Gui yuantianju’”, no. 2, SSSJ, 39.2104–5.

The poet declares nature to be a fellow author; all he needs to do is record the wonderful lines that the river has imparted to him. Ironically, he apologises for being too drunk to be that faithful scribe, although he is still able to commemorate his oblivion. Rhetorically, drunkenness loosens the grip of consciousness and brings the poet closer to a state of spontaneity. It appears that the poet, in the soft dissolution of consciousness, feels at one with the flowing river, itself a symbol of spontaneous creation. But, if nature does not write poetry after all, it is then the silent poetry of spontaneity that finally eludes the sober poet. Whatever comes to his brush is already a cultivated language, mediated moreover by cultural memory and paradigms of the past. Even here, “vast nebulousity” (*miaomang* 渺莽) might not have occurred naturally to Su Shi; he may have said so only to match Tao Qian’s rhyme *mang* 莽. The *mang* in Tao’s line represents the vegetation to be consumed by the merciless seasonal forces; while, for Su, it is the oceanic unconsciousness that he willingly falls into. Nature is no longer ruthless and insentient, but benign and protective of the human cause. Su Shi’s frequent rhetorical technique of personification implies a pervasive homocentric perspective, a reassertion of the self as the centre of the observation.

A Poetic Ethnography

As Su reconstructs the landscape, he also develops a way of reenvisioning the local native’s ethnicity. To begin with, the Chinese writing system itself encoded a certain Han ethnocentrism. Huizhou aborigines were addressed as Dan 蜃. As a variant of *yan* 蜒 (‘slug’), this etymologically derogative term referred to an ethnic group who lived in boats on the water. The natives of Hainan were called Li 黎, the namesake of a local mountain: Limu, or ‘Mother of Li’ 黎母山. *Li* literally means ‘black’ – a reference to their dark skin caused by the equatorial climate. Since for the Han, dark skin suggested daily toil in the fields, its association implied social, economic and political subjugation. This association had been established and strengthened by these ancient terms for the underclass: *limin* 黎民 (‘dark skinned folks’) or *qianshou* 黔首 (‘heads wrapped in black handkerchiefs’) – the old Qin Dynasty term for the common people. Such ethnic designations evoked the exotic and the alien, as well as the Han’s ethnic superiority.

Su Shi’s colourful report on local customs might have selectively magnified the exotica. According to these reports, in Huizhou he sometimes stepped on snakes and dined on insects.³⁷ In Danzhou, the Li people planted little rice

37 Su Shi, “He Tao ‘Du *Shanhajing*”, no. 13, *SSSJ*, 39.2136.

and dined instead on taro roots and, sometimes, smoked mice and bats.³⁸ They wore coconut hats³⁹ and clothes made from cotton tree fibre;⁴⁰ and they killed oxen in shamanic sacrifices to cure diseases, instead of using them to plough the fields.⁴¹ In his letters to friends across the straits, Su once bitterly wrote, “I and my son are doing fine; but mixing with the Li and the Dan, we barely feel our humanity” 某與兒子粗無病，但黎、蜑雜居，無復人理。⁴² Here, the definition of ‘human’ is constructed ethnically. As Robert Campany points out, eating grain and cooking are presented in the *Book of Rites* as being

among the traits possessed by human beings *par excellence*. Anything less – even if it is the result of natural, local variations – counts as less than fully human and needs to be modified.⁴³

Su Shi, among the southern natives, appeared to feel the eventual dissolution of his own ethnic identity, or even his humanity (*renli* 人理).

However, these traces of despair that were articulated in private epistles were rarely found in his poetry, where, more often than not, he celebrated rustic society. He again aspired to model himself after Tao Qian, who, in his poetry, cordially drinks with his farmer neighbours⁴⁴ or casually chats with them in passing on a village road.⁴⁵ To emulate this spirit, Su Shi wrote the following couplets:

I.

江鷗漸馴集
蜑叟已還往

River gulls get familiar and gather around me;
an old man of Dan has become my company.⁴⁶

38 Su Shi, “He Tao ‘Quannong’ liushou” 和陶勸農六首, *SSSJ*, 41.2254–57; “Wen Ziyong shou” 聞子由瘦, *SSSJ*, 41.2257–58.

39 Su Shi, “He Tao ‘Quannong’ liushou”; “Yeziguan” 椰子冠, *SSSJ*, 41.2268–9.

40 Su Shi, “He Tao ‘Nigu jiushou’” 和陶擬古九首, no. 9, *SSSJ*, 41.2266.

41 Su Shi, “Shu Liu Zihou ‘Niufu’ hou” 書柳子厚牛賦後, *SSWJ*, 66.2058.

42 Su Shi, “Yu Cheng Quanfu shiershou” 與程全父十二首, no. 9, *SSWJ*, 55.1626.

43 Robert Ford Campany, “The Meaning of Cuisine of Transcendence in Late Classical and Early Medieval China”, *T’oung-Pao* (2005) 91.1/3: 8–9.

44 See, e.g., Tao Qian, “Yinjiu” no. 9 and no. 14, *TYM*, 3.256, 268; “Lianyu duyin” 連雨獨飲, *TYM*, 2.125 (where the neighbour sent some wine); “Guimaosui shichun huaigu tianshe ershou” 癸卯歲始春懷古田舍二首, no. 2, *TYM*, 3.203 (where he sent some wine to a new neighbour).

45 See Tao Qian, “Gui yuantianju”, no. 2, *TYM*, 2.83.

46 Su Shi, “He Tao ‘Gui yuantianju’”, no. 2, *SSSJ*, 39.2103.

II.

一與蜚叟醉
蒼顏兩摧頹

Getting drunk with an old man of Dan –
two greying faces glow in utter waste.⁴⁷

III.

鳩舌倘可學
化爲黎母民

Were it possible to acquire their butcherbird tongue,
I shall transform to a native below Mt Mother of Li.⁴⁸

In couplet I, Su Shi refers to a story in *Liezi* 列子, where river gulls would gather around a guileless fisherman, until one day he was persuaded by his father to catch the gulls. However, the gulls discerned his treacherous intentions and refused to fly down.⁴⁹ In this couplet, Su Shi wants to reassure his reader that he has forgotten all chicanery, so that river gulls and even an “old man of Dan” keep his company. This parallelism suggests a perspective from which the local Dan natives are viewed on a par with natural creatures. The viewer places himself in a position of active agency, observing and commentating on the passive local subjects. The “old man of Dan” does not speak; like the river gulls, he is a stage prop to witness the author’s claimed dissolution of his cultural and social superiority.

Couplet II celebrates the unassuming way in which he goes on a drinking spree with an “old man of Dan”. We do not know whether this is the same old man mentioned in couplet I, or another (or indeed a fictitious one). As in couplet I, this good friend of Su’s is identified only by his gender, age and ethnicity. These generic features make him less of an individual and more of a stereotype. In contrast, in Tao Qian’s scenes of drinking parties, though his neighbours are also unidentified, they are often endowed with agency, capable of initiating events or giving speeches. Such realistic details make Tao’s rustic company more convincingly individualistic, if not necessarily less fictive.

In couplet III, the author jovially shows the alacrity with which he wishes to become a native of Li – if only he was able to acquire their “butcherbird tongue”. In Hainan, Su Shi apparently suffered from linguistic alienation. He did not understand the native Hainan dialect but was able to tutor some local students, who perhaps could speak in a modified and standardised version of the dialect. Su Shi, after decades of his itinerant bureaucratic career across eastern, central and northern China, must have understood, if not spoken,

47 Su Shi, “He Tao ‘Xiasun tianshe huo’” 和陶下潁田舍獲, *SSSJ*, 42.2316.

48 Su Shi, “He Tao ‘Tianshe shichun huaigu ershou’” 和陶田舍始春懷古二首, no. 2, *SSSJ*, 41.2281.

49 See Yang Bojun 楊伯峻, *Liezi jishi* 列子集釋 (Beijing: Zhonghua shuju, 1979), 2.67–8.

more than one dialect. Yet nowhere else during his provincial tenures did he comment in writing upon the local accent.⁵⁰ In Hainan alone, not only did the native people appear as innocent natural creatures, but their language also resembled bird chirps, deprived of meaning to the ‘cultured’ ear. The political, economic and cultural dominance of the Han Chinese was simultaneously understood as an anthropological advantage. Su Shi’s incapacity to learn the local dialect was regarded as physiological – since his tongue, literally, was that of a human and not of a butcherbird.

These zoogeographical metaphors – assigning images of animals to represent ethnic groups of different regions – were certainly applied only to local natives, alien to Han culture and unable to read such verses. Nevertheless, these poems would have been read by local elite, including officials, students and other members of the gentry, as well as by members of Buddhist or Daoist clerical orders. Su Shi clearly did not mean to insult his local friends and hosts; he used such metaphors because they were integrated into the established cultural hierarchy. Presumably his local hosts were sympathetic, or at least accustomed, to the viewpoint of Han cultural dominance.

Equally notable is the difference between genres: when Su Shi’s prose laments his dislocation, his poetry romanticises his relocation. This discrepancy betrays an element of deliberate persuasion in Su Shi’s vow of assimilation. Furthermore, to blend his own outlandish figure into a cast of local characters, Su Shi’s other approach is to dress them in outfits of cultural archetypes. As a result, if at first the alien people of the south strike Su Shi as being virtually part of nature, on second thoughts he suspects their hidden intelligence or humanity, with their apparent innocence resembling the disguises of recluses or earthly immortals.

This second approach also partly derives from Tao Qian’s poetry. For instance, in Tao Qian’s ninth poem in “Imitation of the Old”, he depicts a ‘scholar of the East’ who lives in deprivation (eating only nine times in thirty days and changing his hat once in ten years), but exhibits divine physical and spiritual wellbeing. Evidently, this is a Daoist figure nourished not by normal food but by cosmic energy (*qi* 氣). Tao Qian expresses a desire to follow him “from now on to the time of cold”.⁵¹ The “time of cold” (*suihan* 歲寒) refers to a cosmic winter when man must rely on his own inner source of warmth to fight against

50 Su Shi seemed to be well-versed in dialects. There is an anecdote which tells that he deduced that a figure in Li Gonglin’s painting was from Fujian, just from the unique shape of the person’s mouth in pronouncing “six”. See *SSNP*, 30.977.

51 See Tao Qian, “Nigu jiushou” 擬古九首, no. 5, *TYM*, 4.327. In the edition used by Su Shi, it is the ninth poem.

forces of mortality like age, disease and death. This poem could be read either as Daoist or as a moral allegory.

Su Shi matched this poem twice. In the first instance, he transforms this 'scholar of the East' into a woodcutter of Li ethnicity:

黎山有幽子
形槁神獨完
負薪入城市
笑我儒衣冠
生不聞詩書

豈知有孔顏
翛然獨往來
榮辱未易關
日暮鳥獸散
家在孤雲端
問答了不通
歎息指屢彈
似言君貴人
草莽棲龍鸞

遣我古貝布
海風今歲寒

There is a secluded mister in the Mountain of Li,
his form wizened, his spirit alone remains intact.
Bearing a load of firewood to the market in town,
he laughs at my scholar's robe and hat.
In his life he has never heard of the *Odes* or the
Documents,
not to mention knowing Confucius or Master Yan.
In utter freedom, he comes and goes all alone;
glory or disgrace hardly crosses his mind.
At sunset, birds and beasts retreat to their hidings;
he heads to a home atop the lonely clouds.
I barely understand his questions or replies;
I sigh and flick my fingers in despair.
He appears to say, "You, sir, are of noble standing;
like a dragon or a simurgh, you come to nestle among
the weeds".
He presents me a bolt of cotton tree cloth –
the sea wind of this season is cold.⁵²

This "secluded mister" enriches the repertoire of proverbial woodcutters in recluse literature. Like Tao Qian's scholar who is nourished by immaterial energy, his intact spirit defies the decline of his form. He is a son of nature, never blighted by education. He laughs at Su Shi's scholarly attire, just as in the *Analects* when the world-traveller Confucius was jeered at by recluses who preferred to keep their virtue private.⁵³ The woodcutter's ignorance of Confucian sages was proof that his virtue developed naturally, instead of being cultivated according to moral commands. Like a Daoist figure, he roams in freedom and cares little about worldly affairs. Su could barely understand him, a speaker of the "butcherbird tongue". Yet, the woodcutter recognises Su Shi as a man of standing, now in misfortune. He may not be aware of Su's spectacular talents or the political theatre in the distant world across the straits, yet he appears to have grasped Su Shi's condition intuitively. He presents a token of empathy – a

52 Su Shi, "He Tao 'Nigu jiushou'", no. 9, *SSSJ*, 41.2266.

53 See *Analects* 18.5–8.

bolt of plain, warm, homespun cloth. The portrayal of this woodcutter combines elements from various poetic stereotypes: a recluse who reveals his identity on encountering a traveller, an earthly immortal, and an enigmatic *zhiyin* 知音 – a kindred spirit who understands one's wordless music.

Su Shi's self-image in this poem is constructed through the eyes of a common man. His moral stature, demeaned in the capital, is recognised by someone whose genuine nature is not distorted by the establishment. By depicting the periphery as morally superior to the centre, Su Shi sends to his readers, especially those at the central court, a political complaint.

The woodcutter of Mt Li provides an image of a man whose desirability derives from what he is not – that is, not exposed to learning, not caring about worldly power or glory and not enmeshed in the network of meaning. Su Shi cannot become a native of Mt Li because his 'natural state' was irrevocably lost in the past. Even in his 'return', Tao Qian style, the acquired traces of culture are so deeply inscribed onto him that they become the very essence of his identity. Thus, his poetry betrays a perpetual struggle between deliberate abandonment and adherence to his political and cultural self. Another poet whom Su Shi frequently read in Huizhou and Danzhou was Liu Zongyuan 柳宗元 (773–819). According to Lu You 陸遊 (1125–1210), Su once called Tao and Liu his "two friends in my banishment to the south".⁵⁴ When Liu Zongyuan was banished to Yongzhou 永州 (in modern Hunan Province), he turned himself into a cultural force committed to the noble cause of 'transforming the barbarians'.⁵⁵ Su Shi explicitly opposed this approach and once declared:

莫學柳儀曹	I should not be like Mr. Liu, Vice Director of the
	Ministry of Rites,
詩書教氓獠	preaching the <i>Odes</i> and the <i>Documents</i> to the savages. ⁵⁶

Yet, despite all his claims of losing a sense of rank and cultural identity, some revealing cases show that Su Shi defended his identity all the more against the threat of alien surroundings.

Su Shi was not officially obligated to 'transform the barbarians'. Under the Tang and the Song, exiled officials often assumed various local administrative

54 See Lu You 陸遊, *Laoxue'an biji* 老學庵筆記 (Beijing: Zhonghua shuju, 1979), 9.120.

55 See, e.g., Liu Zongyuan, "Tong Liu Ershiba yuanzhang shujiu yanhuai ganshi shushi" 同劉二十八院長述舊言懷感時書事, in *Liu Hedong ji* 柳河東集 (Shanghai: Shanghai renmin chubanshe, 1974), 42.674–9.

56 See Su Shi, "Jiang guo Guangzhou yong Guo yun ji Mai Dai erzi" 將過廣州用過韻寄邁迨二子, *SSSJ*, 44.2390.

and educational duties. Han Yu and Liu Zongyuan were magistrates in charge of prefectural affairs, and Su Che was a tax clerk in Yunzhou 筠州 (now Gao'an 高安, Jiangxi Province). Su Shi, however, was typically discharged of all duties in his exiles, probably because of the malice felt towards him.⁵⁷ Even so, Su could not help feeling an obligation to public affairs.⁵⁸ In Huizhou, he dispensed medicine, built a bridge and advised on the construction of the aqueduct system in Guangzhou. Half a year after coming to Danzhou, he composed a series of poems matching Tao's "Exhorting Farmers" (Quannong 勸農) in the classical tetrasyllabic metre, for the apparent purpose of promoting agriculture and sericulture among the (probably illiterate) natives.⁵⁹ In Tao Qian's time, 'exhorting farmers' was a county official's duty.⁶⁰ Tao possibly composed these poems in his capacity as libationer (*jijiu* 祭酒), a minor educational office in the prefecture.⁶¹ As a man out of office, however, Su's "Exhorting Farmers" poems projected him as an overseer of the farmers, therefore falsifying his repeated claim of becoming one of them.

This constant change of positions between the dissolution and the reaffirmation of his identity is a staple of Su Shi's late poetry, and such a paradoxical image might have been deliberate. Unlike Tao Qian, Su Shi enjoyed a huge and zealous contemporary audience. Tao, obscure in his time, explicitly recommended his words to the "later-born".⁶² This gesture of writing for future readers recalls similar remarks from Confucius, Sima Qian and Yang Xiong, cultural heroes who suffered from being misunderstood by their contemporaries, and so entrusted their memory to future generations. In contrast, though Su Shi must have like-mindedly written for the "later-born", he was keenly aware of his popularity. According to Zhu Bian 朱弁 (1085–1144), even in Su Shi's youth, the things he wrote were immediately copied and broadly recited.⁶³ Scholars have argued that after the Crow Terrace prosecution, Su Shi became wary of the dissemination of his works, and this wariness left its impact on his literary compositions.⁶⁴ According to rumour, Su was banished to Hainan after Chancellor Zhang Dun 章惇 (1035–1105) read a poem that celebrated his easy life in

57 As noted in Tomlonovic, *Poetry of Exile*, 192–3.

58 On Su Shi's engagement with social problems in a private capacity, see Egan, *Word, Image, and Deed*, 127–33.

59 Su Shi, "He Tao 'Quannong' liushou", *SSSJ*, 41.2254–57.

60 See "Zhiguanzhi" 職官志 in *Jinshu*, 24.746.

61 See Yuan Xingpei's note to this poem, *TYM*, 1.35–6.

62 Tao Qian, "You hui er zuo yishou bing xu" 有會而作一首并序, *TYM*, 3.306.

63 See Wu Wenzhi, *Song shihua*, vol. 3, 2950.

64 See Uchiyama Seiya 内山精也. "Tōba Utai Shi'an ryūten kō" 「東坡烏台詩案」流传考, *Yokohama Shiritsu Daigaku ronsō* 横浜市立大学論叢 (1996), 47.3: 111–48.

Huizhou.⁶⁵ Even before his exile ended, his Hainan poetry was already circulating in the mainland. Directly after his death, when the government placed a ban on his writing, his ‘overseas poetry’ still enjoyed such popularity that whoever could not recite these poems was at a disadvantage in conversation.⁶⁶ Bearing his contemporary readership in mind, Su Shi must have cautiously controlled his poetic persona. Thus, although on the one hand he gaily reported every step of his ‘return into nature’, on the other he reassured his reader that he never forgot the good Confucian’s responsibility to domesticate the barbaric natives. These two sides combined to create a powerful, albeit paradoxical, political persona who loftily transcended worldly affairs, while dutifully observing moral commands – the very moral paradox that ennobled ancient paragons of reclusion.⁶⁷

By any account, Su Shi remained a cultural force. Soon after he arrived in Hainan, a friend sent him more than a thousand fascicles of books across the sea.⁶⁸ Su might have generously used these books to tutor local students, who kept him constant company.⁶⁹ In turn, he sometimes advised them in matters of writing and calligraphy.⁷⁰ A certain Jiang Tangzuo 姜唐佐 (*jīnshì* 1103) was especially gifted.⁷¹ Since no candidate from Hainan had ever succeeded in the metropolitan exam, Su Shi encouraged Jiang to “break Heaven’s desertion” (*pō tianhuang* 破天荒). Two years after Su Shi’s death, Jiang finally succeeded.⁷² Even though Su Shi never made an explicit commitment to ‘transforming the barbarians’, his contemporaries, nevertheless, were keen to point out his fore-

65 This anecdote was first recorded by Zeng Jili 曾季狸 (twelfth century); see *Tingzhai shihua* 艇齋詩話 (Hong Kong: Guangwen shuju, 1971), 66–7. The concrete plot was not necessarily accurate, but Zhang Dun’s desire to see Su Shi dead perhaps was. More on this story, see ch. 5, 193.

66 See Wu Wenzhi, *Song shihua*, vol. 3, 2950.

67 See Vervoorn, *Men of the Cliffs*, 28–40, 229; Berkowitz, *Patterns of Disengagement*, 20–35.

68 See Su Shi, “He Tao ‘Zeng Yang zhangshi’” 和陶贈羊長史, *SSSJ*, 41.2281–2.

69 See e.g., Su Shi, “Beijiu duxing, bianzhi Ziyun, Wei, Hui, Xianjue sili zhi she, sanshou” 被酒獨行遍至子雲威徽先覺四黎之舍三首, *SSSJ*, 42.2322–3; “Yong Guo yun, Dongzhi yu zhusheng yinjiu” 用過韻冬至與諸生飲酒, *SSSJ*, 42.2324–5; “Zeng Li Si Yanwei xiucai” 贈李兕彥威秀才, *SSSJ*, 43.2352–3; etc.

70 See Fei Gun, *Liangxi manzhi*, 4.2.

71 For Su Shi’s correspondence with Jiang, see Su Shi, “Yu Jiang Tangzuo xiucai liushou” 與姜唐佐秀才六首, *SSWJ*, 57.1739–40.

72 This story is authenticated by Su Che; see Su Che, “Bu Zizhan ‘Zeng Jiang Tangzuo xiucai’ bing yin” 補子瞻贈姜唐佐秀才並引, *Su Che ji, houji*, 3.909.

sight and beneficial cultural influence⁷³ – an influence that, ironically, belied his claim of assimilation into the native folk.

The Poetry of Discontent

In a number of poems written during this last period of exile, Su Shi meditated upon the value of the individual and concluded that it should not be sacrificed for a vague ‘public good’ or absolute loyalty to the sovereign ruler. For Chinese literati, the dilemma between public service and disengagement was perpetual. Tao declared, of all literati:

或擊壤以自歡	Some delight themselves in the game of ‘hitting the wood-stick’;
或大濟於蒼生	some bring great benefit to the whole humble populace. ⁷⁴

Rang 壤 is a shoe-shaped stick made of wood. In the game, one first plants a stick some distance ahead and then throws another to hit it. A story tells that an octogenarian, living in Emperor Yao’s reign, was playing this game by the roadside. When an onlooker praised the virtue of the Emperor who ensured his happiness, the old man retorted:

I rise when the sun rises; I rest when the sun sets. I dig a well to drink and plough the fields to eat. What does the power of the Emperor have to do with me?

日出而作，日入而息。凿井而饮，耕田而食。帝力于我何有哉？⁷⁵

The original moral lesson is the Daoist ideal of governance without interference. Tao Qian, however, used this reference to illustrate an example of private virtue which delights only its possessor. Yet Tao’s poetry does sometimes

73 This story is also related in Shao Bo 邵博, *Shaoshi wenjian houlu* 邵氏聞見後錄 (Beijing: Zhonghua shuju, 1983), 17.133–4.

74 Tao Qian, “Gan shibuyu fu” 感士不遇賦, *TYM*, 5.431–3.

75 See Huangfu Mi 皇甫謐, *Gaoshi zhuan* 高士傳 (Congshu jicheng edition. Shanghai: Shangwu yinshuguan, 1937), 1.6.

betray an anxiety over leading a life wasted and unfulfilled.⁷⁶ So, despite his awareness that to “bring great benefit to the whole humble populace” was noble and laudable, what accounted for Tao’s resignation? Was it simply because of those quotidian scribbles and squabbles in a lowly bureaucrat’s humdrum life? Did he just prefer the rural quietude? The war-ridden interregnum of Tao’s times had spurred speculation, ever since the Late Tang, that his resignation had been of a grander nature, such as a protest against the moral and ritual disorder of the age. According to this version, Tao’s choice was totally consistent with the Confucian attitude of seeking employment with dedication, until all measures are tried and failed in an age of darkness.⁷⁷ As Aat Vervoorn describes it:

The gentleman serves in office as long as by doing so, he can further the Way; once that becomes impossible he must resign to avoid moral compromise.⁷⁸

This orthodox reading was inconvenient for Su Shi’s identification with Tao. Unlike Tao Qian, Su was a prominent political figure and had to carefully avoid criticising the current regime. A hint of frustration would be noted as *lèse majesté*, inappropriate at the least and deadly at the most. Perhaps in regard to the potential censorship, Su Shi contended that Tao Qian (and he himself) were simply endowed with a “partial nature”, ill-fitted to the world. Both Tao’s and his return were but a natural result of their disposition:

嗟我與先生
所賦良奇偏
人間少宜適
惟有歸耘田

Alas, you and me, sir –
both are endowed with an extremely partial nature.
Nothing, if any, befits or pleases us in the realm of man;
returning and ploughing the fields is all we can
muster.⁷⁹

To support this image of Tao, Su Shi highlights a fact in Tao Qian’s *résumé*: his initial acceptance of official appointment. Unlike the usual opinion that sees Tao’s bureaucratic career only as a necessary condition for his resignation, Su argues that Tao’s taking office and his resignation were both motivated by his

⁷⁶ On Tao Qian’s sense of social mission, see Kwong, “Naturalness and Authenticity”, 37–40.

⁷⁷ See Swartz, *Reading Tao*, 55–73, *passim*.

⁷⁸ Vervoorn, *Men of the Cliffs*, 30.

⁷⁹ Su Shi, “He Tao ‘Yuanshi shi Pang Deng’” 和陶怨詩示龐鄧, *SSSJ*, 41.2271.

authentic self, dictated by concrete circumstances and not by any grand moral agenda.

淵明初亦仕
弦歌本誠言

不樂乃徑歸
視世羞獨賢

Yuanming initially also entered officialdom;
it was sincere of him to say that ritual music was his
livelihood.

Taking no delight in it, he simply returned;
looking at the world, he was ashamed to be virtuous
alone.⁸⁰

Xiange 弦歌, or ‘string music and singing’, refers to a story in the *Analects*. Confucius’ disciple, Ziyou 子游, was once the Magistrate of Wucheng 武城 (in modern Shandong Province). Despite the insignificance of this county, he taught students to play courtly music and chant the *Odes*, much to the master’s amused approval.⁸¹ Tao Qian, however, reportedly claimed that he would consider the appointment of County Magistrate only in order to provide for his family.⁸² Su Shi came to understand Tao Qian’s official career in this light under the influence of Ouyang Fei 歐陽斐 (1047–1113), Ouyang Xiu’s son and Su Shi’s in-law.⁸³ Tao’s unpretentious motivation showed his true aversion to power. Understood as such, what drove Tao into officialdom was not moral or political idealism but plain and honest human need. Even more unbearable than hunger was his discovery that he took no delight in bureaucratic life; thus, he ‘simply returned’.

In this interpretation, Tao Qian’s behaviour was motivated solely by hunger and delight, two of the most visceral, instinctive drives of life. Its instinctiveness reveals the authenticity of his state of mind, which was unaffected by external moral teachings. This view of spontaneous morality adheres to Su Shi’s

80 Su Shi, “He Tao ‘Pinshi’ qishou” 和陶貧士七首, no. 2, *SSSJ*, 39.2138.

81 See *Analects* 17.3.

82 See Tao Qian’s biography in “Yinyizhuan” 隱逸傳, *Jinshu*, 64.2461.

83 Su Shi’s second son, Su Dai 蘇迨 (1070–1126), married Ouyang Fei’s daughter in the third month of 1091; see Kong Fanli, *SSNP*, 30.970. Later that year, Su Shi was appointed the Magistrate of Yingzhou, where, at the time, Ouyang Fei was living in retreat. Towards the end of that year, during a visit, he suggested to Su Shi that Tao’s “superior insight” lay in entering officialdom simply because of the lack of provisions at home; see Su Shi, “Ouyang Shubi jianfang, song Tao Yuanming shi, tan qi jueshi [...]” 歐陽叔弼見訪誦陶淵明事嘆其絕識 [...], *SSSJ*, 34.1815. In another poem, Su Shi describes Ouyang Fei in similar terms, “Your learning of the Way has recently gained new insight/out of poverty, however, you now reenter officialdom” 學道新有得，為貧聊復仕; see “Yi ping shan zeng Ouyang Shubi” 以屏山贈歐陽叔弼, *SSSJ*, 34.1823.

definition of a 'sage': the one who takes delight in the Way, not the one who knows the most about it. The 'pleasure principle' serves as an instinctive guide for one's moral behaviour. When facing tough choices in life, one should not let analytic reason interfere, but reach a decision according to one's innate inclinations. If one finds no pleasure in trying to rectify the depraved world, then one should stop trying and keep one's virtue private. As Su Shi indicates, this is the egoistical model of 'for oneself' that Tao Qian establishes.

In the late spring of 1097, Su Shi was obliged to leave his newly built house in Huizhou as he was banished farther away, across the straits to Hainan. Su Che too was banished farther away to Leizhou 雷州 (in modern Guangdong Province). The two brothers travelled together to the port and bid farewell – their last farewell, as their instinct foreboded. From their youth, the two always slept in the same room when travelling; this time they spent one last sleepless night together – sleepless for Su Shi partly due to his affliction with haemorrhoids, a chronic condition he developed in Huangzhou. Su Che thus recited Tao Qian's "Stop Drinking" (Zhijiu 止酒) poem, since alcohol would have exacerbated the ailment. Su Shi later matched Tao's poem to show his resolution.⁸⁴ The beginning lines recount how they both fell into their predicament:

時來與物逝
路窮非我止

與子各意行
同落百蠻裏

When the time comes, we depart along with things;
when the road comes to an end, we stop despite our
will.

You and I each took a journey at our own whim,
and have similarly fallen amidst a hundred barbarian
tribes.

With a few broad strokes of time and fate, the poem presents two brothers of extraordinary talent being swept up by powerful scourges across the central plains, briefly coming together at the margins of a landmass, only to be separated again by a surging ocean. Then, Su Shi paraphrased his brother's suggestion:

勸我師淵明
力薄且爲己
微疴坐杯酌
止酒則瘳矣
望道雖未濟
隱約見津溪

You advise me to follow the example of Yuanming,
since my capacity is low, I should consider for my own.
This ailment is caused by many cups of wine;
stop drinking, and it will be cured.
Gazing at the way, I have not yet reached its coast;
but afar, I can vaguely discern the ford and shore.

84 Su Shi, "He Tao 'Zhijiu'" 和陶止酒, SSSJ, 41.2245–6.

Su Shi's apology for his 'low capacity' could be read both as low tolerance to alcohol and as his limited capacity in practising the Way. Similarly, the 'way' that the poet gazes at might be read either as the actual way of banishment or, metaphorically, as the Way writ large – the ultimate truth, as encoded in the word "ford" (referring to Confucius' search for a chance to practise his philosophy in actual governance).⁸⁵ In the case of Su Shi, however, his "ford" may not be the grand truth of salvaging the world, but the individual truth of ascertaining self-knowledge. This, however, awaits him only across the ocean, reachable after he abandons the central realm and all its political and cultural identities, when he will be left with himself alone.

Su Che recommended the teaching of 'for oneself' (*weiji* 爲己) as a cure to Su Shi's ailments. This term also comes from the *Analects*, where Confucius states, "People of the olden times studied for themselves; people today study for others" 古之學者爲己，今之學者爲人.⁸⁶ To study 'for oneself' is the noble choice: only by enriching oneself independently of the whimsical expectations of the time can one adhere to permanent principles. While Su Shi regarded Tao Qian as a paradigm of virtue kept 'for oneself', this quotation of Confucius' exhortation might also have masked a deep change in Su Shi's political thinking – that is, a loss of faith in loyal and complete dedication to the service of the throne. Instead, a literatus, even in the role of a bureaucrat, was entitled to cultivate his private sphere outside the public realm.

This message is encoded in Su Shi's reflection on the 'Three Worthies' (*sanliang* 三良) who died at the funeral of Duke Mu of Qin 秦穆公 (r. 659–621 BCE). According to *Zuozhuan*, they were "used as sacrifice" (*weixun* 爲殉), their deaths were mourned by the metropolitan public (*guoren* 國人), and opinion held it as evidence of Duke Mu's innate cruelty.⁸⁷ *Zuozhuan*'s choice of words suggests that their deaths were not voluntary, but were forced and violent. Yet the commentator Zheng Xuan 鄭玄 (127–200) hypothesised that they must have volunteered to sacrifice themselves out of loyalty.⁸⁸ In 1061, during Su Shi's first official post in Fengxiang 鳳翔 (in modern Shaanxi Prov-

85 In *Analects* 18.6, Changju 長沮 and Jieni 桀溺 were ploughing the fields when Confucius passed by with his disciples. Zilu 子路 was sent to ask for directions to the ford, but was mocked by the recluses for trying to save the world when he did not even know something as simple as that.

86 *Analects* 14.24.

87 *Zuozhuan* Wen 6; see *Chunqiu zuozhuan zhengyi*, 19A.142, SSJZS, 1844.

88 The Mao commentary to the ode "Huangniao" 黃鳥 (Mao 131) seems to suggest that they were forced to die: "The people of the capital criticised King Mu for using humans to follow him in death" (*yiren congsi* 以人從死). The Zheng commentary, however, glosses *congsi* as "suicide" (*zisha* 自殺). See *Maoshi zhengyi*, 6.105, SSJZS, 373.

ince), he seconded Zheng Xuan's opinion in a verse on Duke Mu's tomb, which was a local tourist attraction. He maintained that the people of old had superior morality and were willing to die for the sake of being appreciated by a powerful patron. Such heroic deeds were no longer seen in his day, leading to the suspicion that their deaths were coerced.⁸⁹ It should be mentioned that Su Che, in his matching poem, rejected Su Shi's surmise forthright, arguing that they could better repay the ruler's appreciation by serving his son, the future king; thus, these wise gentlemen could not have chosen a fortuitous death.⁹⁰

Su Che's argument hinged upon the fact that the royal lineage of Qin was not severed. The moral value of loyal dedication itself was not questioned, and his poem did not represent a break with the traditional ideology of personal loyalty.

Su Shi's revised commentary upon the 'Three Worthies' came almost four decades after his initial poem. This time it was in response to Tao Qian. Tao's poem also accepted the alternative tradition that the three had committed suicide, and it related the story based on the account of Ying Shao 應劭 (fl. 153–196). In this version, Duke Mu once sighed at a happy banquet and said that he would very much like someone to share his pleasure in life and his grave in death, so the three volunteered. Their deaths were merely fulfilling their oath.⁹¹ The authenticity of Ying's narrative may be questionable, but it must have found a large audience, including Tao Qian, who was willing to think that the Worthies' choice of death was noble. Tao's poem reveals conflicting emotions. He first sympathises with their entrance into officialdom, an action he interprets as being driven by the fear of an idle life. He subtly disapproves, however, of its consequence, which is that of "being used for the ruler's personal interest" 遂爲君所私. Once the ruler revealed his diabolical wish at an intimate moment, they had no choice but to volunteer. The poet respects their loyalty, yet the tears that are shed onto his robe question the very value of absolute dedication to a capricious ruler.⁹² In this regard, Tao's resignation is a trade-off: he may risk living an idle life, but at least he preserves his most precious self.

Su Shi's response to Tao's thoughtful poem is extraordinary. He dismisses all scholastic sophistication and ambiguities, and completely overturns his youthful admiration for their loyalty. Instead, he argues that there should be a limit

89 Su Shi, "Qin Mugong mu" 秦穆公墓, in "Fengxiang baguan" 鳳翔八觀, *SSSJ*, 3, 118–9.

90 Su Che, "Qin Mugong mu" 秦穆公墓, in "He Zizhan 'Fengxiang baguan' bashou" 和子瞻鳳翔八觀八首, *Su Che ji*, 2.27.

91 As quoted by *Shiji zhengyi* 史記正義; see *Shiji*, 5.195, n. 4.

92 Tao Qian, "Yong Sanliang", *TYM*, 4.383.

to one's service to the ruler. He elaborates on the distinction between the public and the private, declaring that public service should not be equated with the ruler's private wishes, and insisting that individual life has an intrinsic value that should not be sacrificed in vain. He reasons:

此生太山重
忽作鴻毛遺

三子死一言
所死良已微
賢哉晏平仲
事君不以私
我豈犬馬哉
從君求蓋帷
殺身固有道
大節要不虧
君爲社稷死
我則同其歸
顧命有治亂
臣子得從違
魏顆真孝愛

三良安足希

仕宦豈不榮
有時纏憂悲
所以靖節翁

服此黔婁衣

The weight of this life is as heavy as Paramount Tai;
how all of a sudden is it discarded as a goose feather, so
light?

The Three Gentlemen died for a single word –
what they died for was truly, alas, a triviality!
Sagacious was Yan Pingzhong, the Qi minister,
whose service to the ruler was not personal.
Am I a dog, or am I a horse,
that follows the king for an exquisite canopy?
There is a proper way to let oneself die,
that is, one's great integrity shall remain intact.
If the king died for the sake of the state,
I shall then follow his fate.

A royal command may bring order – or chaos;
so the subject can opt to follow – or disobey.
Wei Ke[’s rejection of his father’s wish] showed true
filial affection;

the death of the ‘Three Worthies’ deserves no
admiration!

Doesn’t an official career bring glory?
It sometimes entails sorrow and woe.
For this very reason, the old man Jingjie [aka. Tao
Qian]

chose instead to wear Qianlou’s shabby clothing.⁹³

Of the five historical instances Su Shi cites, the ‘Three Worthies’ are set in contrast against wiser examples. Yan Ying 晏嬰 (?–500 BCE; polite name Pingzhong 平仲) refused to commit suicide after his ruler was murdered, since, as he ar-

93 Su Shi, “He Tao ‘Yong sanliang’” 和陶詠三良, *SSSJ*, 40.2184–5. Qianlou was a lofty, but extremely poor, recluse. When he died, he was covered with a cotton blanket that was too short to cover his head and his feet simultaneously. When someone suggested to his wife that she place the blanket diagonally to cover the whole body, she replied that it was better to be an upright person than to have adequate covering. See Liu Xiang 劉向, *Lienü zhuan huibian* 列女傳彙編 (Beijing: Beijing tushuguan, 2007), 2.192–4.

gued, one should die for a king only when he has died for the sake of the state. As Duke Zhuang 齊莊公 (r. 553–48 BCE) died dishonourably in an act of adultery, Yan mourned for his death as dictated by ritual, but would do nothing more.⁹⁴ Wei Ke 魏顆 (sixth century BCE) similarly defied his father's last wish to kill his favourite concubine as sacrifice because such blind obedience would only have tarnished his father's fine reputation.⁹⁵ The 'Three Worthies' thus failed to perform the higher moral command by using their conscientious judgement. Though Su Shi followed the alternative tradition and believed that they died for an oath, their commitment to obeying a despotic request reduced them to being their ruler's pets. The last allusions to Tao Qian and Qianlou further imply that perhaps their very choice of entering officialdom was folly. Power and glory were bought at a dear price: one's precious self.

Su Shi found in the *Book of Changes* the theoretical support for his new understanding on relations between ruler and subject. According to his own commentary, Hexagram 28, "Great Excess" (Da guo 大過), represents an age when the ruler is arrogant and the power of the ministers is shattered. This is because in the *yin* and *yang* binary system, the ruler is in the *yang* position and his ministers are in the *yin* position. The *yang* controls the *yin*, but it could neither exist without the *yin* nor deprive it of its dignity. Neither force should overpower the other.⁹⁶ In his commentary on Hexagram 18, "Decay" (Gu 蠱), he suggests that a virtuous person shall endeavour to rescue the world when he sees the early symptoms of disaster. But, if the situation is beyond rescue, he should stay away from the kings and lords to save his own skin.⁹⁷ In other words, he observes the 'timeliness' (*shi* 時) of retreat. As Aat Vervoorn has argued, this idea of timely service is found across the early Confucian and Daoist classics:

[It] provides a way of finding room for both periods of dutiful service and periods of lofty withdrawal in the individual's relationship with ruler and society. [...] In this way eremitism ceased to be a type of conduct which *prima facie* required moral justification and became something natural and inevitable, a part of the eternal order of things.⁹⁸

94 Zuo zhuan Xiang 25; see *Chunqiu zuozhuan zhengyi*, 36.281, SSJZS, 1983.

95 Zuo zhuan Xuan 15; see *Chunqiu zuozhuan zhengyi*, 24.186, SSJZS, 1888.

96 Su Shi, *Su shi Yi zhuan*, in *San Su quanshu*, vol. 1, 232–3.

97 Ibid., 205.

98 Vervoorn, *Men of the Cliffs*, 68.

Su Shi's change of attitude towards the 'Three Worthies' suggests a shift of emphasis from absolute loyalty to the value of individual life. For a traditional literatus, cultivated to think of morality as having an ultimately altruistic and public purpose, the egoistic option provided an escape into the private sphere, which may find physical abode in a garden, the fields or in a refined studio. In Su Shi's vision, this sphere was essentially an inner utopia that only a meditative mind could reach.

Peach Blossom Spring as an Inner Utopia

In his famous prose narrative with a poem, "Peach Blossom Spring", Tao Qian depicted an autonomous rural society, where residents shunned the external world and were free from governmental interference. Su Shi, alienated from his external environment and not free to complain, discovered instead an inner utopia in Tao's vision. It shared the essential features of a Daoist grotto Heaven and could only be visited by a meditative mind, regardless of location or external situation. It is, in Isaiah Berlin's term, an "inner citadel" where, by disclaiming one's desires for goals in the external world, one becomes the king of an infinite space, contained in a nutshell. One is free from the tyranny of environment, fate or an absolute monarchy – not by removing these obstacles from one's path, but by renouncing even the vaguest desire to go down that path.⁹⁹

In Tao Qian's iconic record, a stray fisherman encounters a clear stream, its banks bearing groves of blossoming peach trees. Rowing against the stream, he finds a narrow entrance to a cave and, on the other side, an open space accommodating a hermetic agrarian community. It had been established centuries earlier by people escaping the warfare that arose at the end of the Qin Dynasty. The hospitable residents have a pleasurable and autonomous life, know no change of kings and pay no taxes. The fisherman goes home, breaks his oath of secrecy and then guides the Magistrate of Wuling 武陵 (in modern Changde, Hunan Province) to find the cave. But Peach Blossom Spring is never found again.¹⁰⁰

Three prominent features contributed to Peach Blossom Spring's lasting appeal: its exclusivity, its utopic symbolism and its half-mythical, half-realistic characteristics. Its residents were humans, but their living space was similar to a Daoist Heaven. As Susan Nelson has argued,

99 See Isaiah Berlin, "Two Concepts of Liberty", in *The Proper Study of Mankind* (New York: Farrar, Straus, and Giroux, 2000), 206–12.

100 Tao Qian, "Taohuayuan ji bing shi", *TYM*, 6.479–80.

[Tao Qian] borrowed elements from fables about Immortals current in his day; however much he modified them, notions of the supernatural were at their origin and core.¹⁰¹

These supernatural associations include the peach blossoms at the entrance (intimating immortality), the tunnel entrance (suggesting a grotto heaven), the stream perhaps nourishing a 'spiritual fount', and the magical disappearance of the entrance upon one's searching for it.¹⁰² These are all common mythemes in Daoist lore. Yet, as Yim-tze Kwong has observed, though this story might be inspired by contemporaneous lore about immortals, its narrative is decidedly realistic, making Peach Blossom Spring "at once utopian and this-worldly".¹⁰³

Su Shi's reenvisioning of the Peach Blossom Spring was not just based on Tao's account and poem, but also on their extensive subsequent literary reception. From the Six Dynasties on, but particularly in the Tang Dynasty, Peach Blossom Spring became a popular poetic motif. It was used as a facile synonym either of a princely estate or a grotto heaven. The former is exemplified in the following poem from Yu Xin 庾信 (513–581):

梁王修竹園 冠蓋風塵喧 行人忽枉道 直進桃花源	The Prince of Liang's garden of slender bamboos – their crowns overtop the clamour of wind and dust below. A passenger may suddenly go astray, and intrude straight into a Peach Blossom Spring. ¹⁰⁴
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Similarly to Tao Qian's vision, this Peach Blossom Spring is also an exclusive space. Ironically, however, its residents are no longer farmers escaping despotic rule, but the rulers themselves. The tall bamboos, looming over the dust and clamour, symbolise their power. The hapless passenger is a parody of the stray fisherman – hospitality surely does not await him. At best he will be expelled as a joke by the laughing Prince and his guests. Peach Blossom Spring is no longer a classless society, but a privatised, privileged space – the ruthlessness of which is revealed only upon intrusion. In other poems mentioning Peach

101 Susan Nelson, "On through to the Beyond: the Peach Blossom Spring as Paradise", *Archives of Asian Art* (1986), 39: 26.

102 *Ibid.*, 25–6.

103 Kwong, "Naturalness and Authenticity", 49.

104 Yu Xin, "Fengbao Zhaowang huijiu shi" 奉報趙王惠酒詩, *XQHW*, "Beizhou" 3.2377.

Blossom Spring before the Tang, the motif all refers to an aestheticised, artificial garden.¹⁰⁵

This use of Peach Blossom Spring extended well into the Tang Dynasty. During the Tang, Peach Blossom Spring as a literary motif gained popular currency, verging on the *cliché*. As an allusion and a motif, it appears in more than two hundred poems in *Quan Tang shi* 全唐詩, called alternatively *taohuayuan* 桃花源, *taoyuan* 桃源, *huayuan* 花源, *Wuling yuan* 武陵源 or *Wuling xi* 武陵溪. A number of these poems describe the princely estates of “weekend rec-luses”. As Stephen Owen has argued,

[Tang estate poetry featured] an encounter of antithetical extremes, in which the center of political power [...] and the place defined by its rupture from centered political space [...] came together.

The example that he raises is Shen Quanqi’s 沈佺期 (656?–714?) formulation: “Peach Blossom Spring meets the Ninefold Palace” 桃花源接九重.¹⁰⁶ Such a suburban estate marked an exclusive space in nature, distinct from the urban. Its residents enjoyed the relative freedom afforded by their temporal distance from the centre of power – yet also, paradoxically, by their privileged access to wealth and power.

Another common use of Peach Blossom Spring in Tang poetry was as an escapist, pristine realm of transcendence. As the Southern Song author Hong Mai observed, residents in Tao Qian’s original “Peach Blossom Spring” were mortals, but Tang poets generally depicted the space as a supernatural realm accommodating earthly immortals.¹⁰⁷ Those mythemes, latent in Tao’s depiction, proliferated into various combinations and elaborations. Wang Wei’s “Song of Peach Blossom Spring” (Taoyuan xing 桃源行), for instance, clearly declares that the farmers who ran away from war and tyranny somehow became immortal:

105 Aside from the poem above in Lu Qinli’s book, the Peach Blossom Spring is mentioned in another three poems prior to the Tang. The second poem, also from Yu Xin (“Yong huapingfeng shi er shiwushou” 詠畫屏風詩二十五首, no. 5, *XQHW*, “Beizhou” 4.2395), refers similarly to a princely estate; the third, to a mountain villa (Xu Ling 徐陵, “Shanzhai shi” 山齋詩, *XQHW*, “Chen” 5.2530); and the fourth, to a Buddhist temple (Kong Deshao 孔德紹, “Deng Baimashan Humingsi shi” 登白馬山護明寺詩, *XQHW*, “Sui” 6.2721–2).

106 Stephen Owen, “The Formation of the Tang Estate Poem”, *Harvard Journal of Asiatic Studies* (1995), 55.1: 44, 46. Shen Quanqi’s line is from “Fenghe xing Wei Sili shanzhuang shiyan yingzhi” 奉和幸韋嗣立山莊侍宴應制, *QTS*, 97.1054.

107 Hong Mai, *Rongzhai suibi, sanbi* 10.548–9.

初因避地去人間 At first they escaped warfare and left the realm of man;
及至成仙遂不還 until they became immortals and would never return.¹⁰⁸

Tao Qian's description of life in Peach Blossom Spring was transplanted onto other conventional themes of immortals' lives, such as dining on turtle shells, drinking stone marrow, wearing deer fur and planting jade or fantastic, efficacious plants.¹⁰⁹ Indeed, Tao's rural utopia had become so closely associated with a Daoist Heaven that it was even listed as such in Daoist scriptures.¹¹⁰ Han Yu, who chided all stories about immortals as nonsensical, nevertheless proceeded to elaborate, in great detail, on a painting of Peach Blossom Spring as a domain of immortality.¹¹¹

Immortals are beings of absolute freedom – free from illness and death, and also free to transform and to act. As a grotto heaven, Peach Blossom Spring was no longer a tax-free shelter for refugee peasants (refusing those less fortunate), nor a high-society garden (refusing the lowly born), but a pleasure house for immortals (denying entrance to mortals altogether). This last vision is at once the most fantastical and the most exclusive.

In Su Shi's matching poem,¹¹² however, he protests against the earlier tradition of depicting Peach Blossom Spring as a Daoist Heaven. He argues in the preface:

Popular legends about Peach Blossom Spring are usually overblown. If we examine Yuanming's record carefully, he only said that their ancestors came to that place to escape the warfare at the end of the Qin. So those whom the fisherman met seemed to be their descendants, not some undead people from the Qin. He also said that they killed chickens for meals. How could an immortal kill [chickens]?

108 Wang Wei, "Taoyuan xing" 桃源行, in Chen Tiemin 陳鐵民, *Wang Wei ji jiaozhu* 王維集校注 (Beijing: Zhonghua shuju, 1997), 1.16–7.

109 See, e.g., Lu Zhaolin, "Guo Dongshan gukou" 過東山谷口, *QTS*, 42.529; Quan Deyu 權德輿, "Taoyuan pian" 桃源篇, *QTS*, 329.3679; Liu Yuxi 劉禹錫, "Taoyuan xing" 桃源行, *QTS*, 356.3995; etc.

110 Listed as *Taoyuan shandong* 桃源山洞 in a "Tiandi gongfu tu" 天地宮府圖; see Zhang Junfang 張君房. *Yunji qiqian* 雲笈七籤 (Beijing: Zhonghua shuju, 2003), 618.

111 Han Yu, "Taoyuan tu" 桃源圖, *QTS*, 338.3787. Discussed also in Nelson, "Through to the Beyond", 27.

112 Su Shi, "He Tao 'Taohuayuan' bing yin" 和陶桃花源并引, *SSSJ*, 40.2196–8.

世傳桃源事，多過其實。考淵明所記，止言先世避秦亂來此，則漁人所見，似是其子孫，非秦人不死者也。又云殺雞作食，豈有仙而殺者乎？

Su Shi notes the residents' non-vegetarian diet and holds it central to his argument. As to be seen later, food is deeply meaningful in defining a space. Susan Nelson remarks that Su Shi was the first person who argued convincingly against describing Peach Blossom Spring as a paradise, initiating an "immortality controversy" on the nature of this place.¹¹³ Yet, while claiming to redeem the "authorial intention" of Tao Qian, Su Shi gave this theme his own twist. For him, many Peach Blossom Springs hide in the world, in secret nooks beyond reach of centralised political or cultural forces – but they are readily accessible in dreams.

An old legend has it that there was a Chrysanthemum Creek in Nanyang. The water was sweet and fragrant. There were some thirty households and they drank from its water. They all lived long, some up to one-hundred-and-twenty or -thirty years.¹¹⁴ Amidst Mount Qingcheng of Sichuan, there was an 'old-man village', where some had lived to see their descendants of the fifth generation. The road to this village was extremely treacherous and long-winding, so all their lives they had never tasted salt or vinegar. There grew many wolfberry trees in the stream, the roots of which were as thick as snakes and dragons. Whoever drank its water lived long. In recent years, the condition of the road has improved, so eventually the residents are able to acquire various kinds of foods and seasonings. Their life expectancy, however, has decreased. Could Peach Blossom Spring also be of that kind? Had the Magistrate of Wuling managed to find it, it would have long become a battlefield of fighting and snatching! In my opinion, there are many places like this between Heaven and Earth, not just Peach Blossom Spring. When I was in Yingzhou, I once dreamt about coming to a government building. The people there did not differ from the mundane, but the mountains and rivers formed a vista clear and vast, which was truly delightful. I looked back into the hall and found a tablet with the inscription 'Qiuchi'. Then I woke up. It occurred to me that Qiuchi used to be the homeland of the Di natives from Wudu, under the

¹¹³ Nelson, "Through to the Beyond", 27–8, and *passim*.

¹¹⁴ A story found in the "Xianyao" 仙藥 chapter of *Baopuzi* 抱朴子; see Wang Ming 王明, *Baopuzi neipian jiaoshi* 抱朴子內篇校釋 (Beijing: Zhonghua shuju, 1985), 11.207–8.

protection of Yang the Irresistible.¹¹⁵ How did I get there? The next day I asked my retainers. One retainer called Zhao Lingshi, whose polite name was Delin, said, “Why should you ask, sir? This is a land of bliss adjunct to the Grotto Heaven. Du Fu once said, ‘The Qiuchi Cave has existed since age immemorial; a secret path leads to it, a minor heaven’.”¹¹⁶ Another day, Wang Qingchen, whose polite name was Zhongzhi, Vice Director in the Ministry of Works, told me, “Once on my return from an envoy trip, I passed by Mt Qiuchi. It was nourished by ninety-nine springs and surrounded by myriad mountains. It was truly a place to hide from the world, just like Peach Blossom Spring”.

舊說南陽有菊水，水甘而芳，民居三十餘家，飲其水，皆壽，或至百二三十歲。蜀青城山老人村，有見五世孫者，道極險遠，生不識鹽醯，而溪中多枸杞，根如龍蛇，飲其水，故壽。近歲道稍通，漸能致五味，而壽益衰。桃源蓋此比也歟。使武陵太守得而至焉，則已化爲爭奪之場久矣。嘗意天壤之間，若此者甚衆，不獨桃源。予在潁州，夢至一官府，人物與俗間無異，而山川清遠，有足樂者。顧視堂上，榜曰仇池。覺而念之，仇池武都氏故地，楊難當所保，余何爲居之。明日，以問客。客有趙令時德麟者，曰：“公何爲問此，此乃福地，小有洞天之附庸也。杜子美蓋云：‘萬古仇池穴，潛通小有天。’”他日工部侍郎王欽臣仲至謂余曰：“吾嘗奉使過仇池，有九十九泉，萬山環之，可以避世，如桃源也。”

According to the *Shuijingzhu* 水經注, Qiuchi is a rocky mountain, cut steep on all sides and with only one winding narrow path leading to the peak; its peak, however, is flat, with three hundred acres of arable land nourished by a rich mountain spring.¹¹⁷ Su Shi's dream visit to Qiuchi must have happened in late 1091 or early 1092, during his tenure in Yingzhou. Since then, Qiuchi became Su Shi's private obsession. Shortly after his transfer to Yangzhou in the spring of

115 Di was the ethnic tribe occupying this region. Wudu 武都 (in modern Gansu Province) is the name Han Wudi gave to this prefecture in 111 BCE. The Yang clan of Di came to live on Qiuchi since the end of the Eastern Han. See Chen Qiaoyi 陳橋驛, *Shuijingzhu jiaozheng* 水經注校證 (Beijing: Zhonghua shuju, 2007), 20.481. Yang Nandang 楊難當 (literally, ‘Yang the Irresistible’) was the Chief of his clan from 429–442, until he was vanquished by the Liu-Song Dynasty. His history is recorded in Sima Guang 司馬光, *Zizhi tongjian* 資治通鑑 (Beijing: Zhonghua shuju, 1956), 121.3978–124.3929.

116 Quote from Du Fu, “Qinzhou zayong” 秦州雜詠, no. 14, in Qiu Zhao'ao 仇兆鰲, *Du shi xiangzhu* 杜詩詳注 (Beijing: Zhonghua shuju, 1979), 7.584.

117 See Chen Qiaoyi, *Shuijingzhu jiaozheng*, 20.481. Qiuchi is today's Mt Changyang 常羊, in modern Gansu Province.

1092, Su Shi acquired the pair of Quichi rocks; he named them after Du Fu's poem and in recollection of his dream.¹¹⁸ Notably, he began the Tao-matching exercise in Yangzhou, around the same time as he acquired the rocks. His admiration of Tao's poetry and the naming of the rocks both hint at the escapist thoughts that increasingly haunted Su's mind. The Quichi rocks accompanied him back to the capital, through his long journey of banishment to Huizhou and Danzhou, and, eventually, on his return to the mainland. They were the daily companions by Su Shi's side, to him symbolising a world beyond.

As the story of the Chrysanthemum Creek shows, the eudaimonic character of such secret domains was protected by their exclusivity, and the intrusion of the outside world would breach its blessed isolation. As Su elaborates in his matching poem, the Peach Blossom Spring is a metaphor for an inner realm of bliss, and access to it is only possible through absolute mental tranquillity:

凡聖無異居
清濁共此世
心閑偶自見
念起忽已逝
欲知真一處
要使六用廢
桃源信不遠
杖藜可小憩

躬耕任地力

絕學抱天藝

臂雞有時鳴
尻駕無可稅
苓龜亦晨吸

Commoners and sages do not differ in their residence;
the pure and the foul share this same world.

When my mind is idle, I catch an occasional glimpse;
but when a single thought stirs, it vanishes like a flash.
To find out where hides the one single truth,
you must abandon your six senses!¹¹⁹

Peach Blossom Spring is truly not far,
reachable by walking with a goosefoot stick while
taking small rests.

There people farm in accordance with the capacity of
the land;
they abandon learning and embrace the heavenly
craft.

The arm-roosters occasionally crow;
but the thigh-carriages cannot be unfastened.¹²⁰
The tuckahoe-turtles also suck the morning air;¹²¹

118 Su Shi, "Shuangshi", *SSSJ*, 35.1880. See also ch. 3, 112.

119 See also ch. 3, fn. 29.

120 In the "Dazongshi" 大宗師 chapter of the *Zhuangzi*, Ziyu 子輿 becomes sick and is asked whether he feels disgusted by his deformed body. He exclaims that he shall accept all kinds of transformations that destiny dictates. If his arm was transformed into a rooster, he would let it crow to announce the time; if his thigh was transformed into a wheel and his spirit to a horse, he would ride this carriage, and so forth. See *ZZJS*, 6.261.

121 The most efficacious tuckahoe is said to assimilate the form of a turtle. In a story related in *Baopuzi*, the turtle sucks in the morning air in a gingerly way and thus gains longevity; see Wang Ming, *Baopuzi neipian jiaoshi*, 3.48.

杞狗或夜吠
耘樵得甘芳

齏齧謝炮製
子驥雖形隔
淵明已心詣
高山不難越
淺水何足厲
不如我仇池
高舉復幾歲
從來一生死
近又等癡慧

蒲澗安期境
羅浮稚川界

夢往從之遊
神交發吾蔽
桃花滿庭下
流水在戶外
卻笑逃秦人
有畏非真契

and wolfberry-dogs occasionally bark at night.¹²²
Farmers and woodcutters find sweet and fragrant things;
they eat them raw without cooking or pickling.
Though Ziji failed to tramp its soil,¹²³
Yuanming already visited it in his mind.
High mountains are not hard to cross;
shallow waters are trivial to wade.
It cannot be compared to my Qiuchi,
raised high above for how many years!
Where life and death are always treated equal;
and lately, the foolish and the clever have also become the same.

The Calamus Gully is the domain of Scholar Anqi;¹²⁴
Mount Luofu is the territory of Zhichuan [aka. Ge Hong].

In dreams I follow their roaming;
the encounter of our spirits shall clear my delusions!
Peach blossoms fill an entire court;
a flowing stream outside of the door.
Now I laugh at those who escaped the Qin despot –
they still had fears – my true kindred spirits they were not!

- 122 A story in the Early Song compendium *Taiping guangji* 太平廣記 tells that Zhu Ruzi 朱孺子, an acolyte to the Daoist Wang Xuanzhen 王玄真, once saw two spotted puppies disappearing into a cave. He told Wang and they dug into the cave together, only to find two spotted wolfberry roots. Wang told Zhu to cook them in an alchemist's tripod. After guarding the fire for three days, Zhu was enticed by the smell and drank the soup. Afterwards, he shared the root with Wang. Zhu became an immortal, while Wang only enjoyed extreme longevity. See *Taiping guangji*, ed. Li Fang 李昉, *SKQS*, 2043.24.7–8. The same comparison of wolfberry to a dog is also used by Su Shi in “Ciyun Zhengfu tongyou Bai-shuishan” 次韻正輔同游白水山, *SSSJ*, 39.2150; “Gouqi” 枸杞, in “Xiaopu wu yong” 小圃五詠, *SSSJ*, 39.2159.
- 123 In Tao Qian's story, Liu Ziji 劉子驥 was a recluse who also wanted to find Peach Blossom Spring, but unfortunately died before setting off on his search. See Tao Qian, “Taohuayuan ji bing shi”, *TYM*, 6.479–80.
- 124 Calamus Gully is in Mt Baiyun 白雲山 (in modern Guangzhou, Guangdong Province), where the calamus grows plenty. In local legend, Scholar Anqi 安期生 found a nine-gnarled calamus root that sprouted purple blossoms, ate it, and became an immortal. See Ji Han 嵇含, *Nanfang caomu zhuang* 南方草木狀, in *Han Wei liuchao biji xiaoshuo daquan* 漢魏六朝筆記小說大觀 (Shanghai: Shanghai guji chubanshe, 1999), 1.256.

In Su Shi's vision, this world of ours is both shared and divided. It is a common space from which no one can escape. But one could have a private realm, separate from the rest of the world: a secluded corner accessible only when the mind is completely void – if a single thought stirs, the entrance closes. The journey to this realm, in other words, is an exercise in mental spontaneity. Paradoxically, the ultimate mobility of spiritual roaming is achieved only in absolute tranquillity.

Living in such a realm, moreover, demands that one dispossess learning and craft. This eudaimonic life is nourished by raw, highly nutritious food. As Su Shi argues in the preface, the people of Nanyang and Qingcheng enjoyed longevity because of the medicinal properties of their water and a plain diet unadulterated by salt or spices. Despite being described as farmers and woodcutters, these residents were gatherers dining on raw food. As Campany argues, in the meaning system of Chinese cuisine, eating grains and cooking are essential characteristics of an agricultural life.¹²⁵ In contrast, the 'cuisine of transcendence' is based on something other than grains, ingested raw (or prepared according to secret methods different to standard cooking techniques), and prepared and consumed ritualistically. An alternative diet is an essential component in the endeavour to transcend the sedentary, agrarian society and its political and ideological hierarchies.¹²⁶ Even though Tao Qian employed Daoist mythemes to construct his Peach Blossom Spring, the chicken-killing, millet-cooking residents are physiologically human. Su Shi noted this point in his preface to support his argument that Peach Blossom Spring is not a grotto heaven. In his matching poem, however, it is precisely their cuisine that is then modified to become raw and seemingly vegetarian. Their distinctive dietary habits have now become consistent with the socioeconomic and political 'otherness' of this community.

The Daoist feature of Su Shi's Peach Blossom Spring is further underlined by its wondrous population, including arm-roosters, thigh-carriages, tuckahoe-turtles and wolfberry-dogs. Human body parts, manufactured objects, plants and animals seem to be in constant metamorphosis, characteristic of the Daoist worldview. According to Isabelle Robinet, the Chinese philosophy of metamorphosis does not perceive the appearance of the world as a creation, and there is no ontological separation or discontinuity in nature. "When arriving at a terminal point of development, each thing reverses itself into its opposite or otherwise changes its form".¹²⁷ Those hybrid beings under Su Shi's brush ap-

¹²⁵ Campany, "Meaning of Cuisine", 8–9.

¹²⁶ *Ibid.*, 50–2.

¹²⁷ Isabelle Robinet, *Taoist Meditation: the Mao-shan Tradition of Great Purity*, trans. Julian F. Pas and Norman J. Girardot (Albany: State University of New York Press, 1993), 154.

pear to be caught at the most revealing moment of their transitional stage, when their forms are still fluid. This seems to imply that the vital density of this magical land facilitates the metamorphosis of things, which are thus constantly found to be in transformation. Understanding the grand transformation of things represents a “hallmark of intellectual knowledge”.¹²⁸ Coming to this land, one’s eyes are opened as one sees the world in its true form.

Those defining features of life at Peach Blossom Spring mirror the life of a Daoist adept, whose meditative spirit roams free, who observes a raw food diet (or ideally dines upon air alone), and who partakes of the metamorphosis of things through chemical or physiological alchemy. This explains Su Shi’s proposal to follow Scholar Anqi and Ge Hong – both famous in local lore – in dream and in fantasy. He laughs at the residents of Peach Blossom Spring, whose discovery was motivated by fear – an undesirable state of mind which hampers spontaneity. Aat Vervoorn writes that “[e]ssential to all eremitism is the element of free choice”; a hermit is properly called a hermit “only if his actions follow from a moral decision rather than merely the pressures of circumstance”.¹²⁹ Therefore, even though these farmers lived at Peach Blossom Spring, they were not practising eremitism since they were not there out of their own free will, nor did they make sacrifices in choosing their life. Yet Su Shi goes beyond extolling the freedom of choice and focuses instead on the spontaneous mental state that follows this exercise of freedom. He implies that one does not need to relinquish one’s worldly abode to go into reclusion. To physically seek a separate realm is already a highly deliberate act, which can be motivated by the unease or fear in one’s external environment. It is therefore an inferior form of access. Access to an *inner* utopia, on the other hand, is gained when one sinks into a state of non-intentionality (as in a dream or in meditation). One no longer needs to find a Peach Blossom Spring in the real world, as long as one can recreate a eudaimonic life through Daoist practice and receive all the mental and physiological bliss that comes along with it.

Compared to earlier visions of Peach Blossom Spring, which all depict an exclusive physical space, Su’s is more egalitarian and more meritocratic: virtually anyone can enter, so long as they reach the level of Su’s ‘kindred spirits’. And, since it exists only in one’s inner space, no stray fisherman or passenger can intrude. It is the ultimate ‘private sphere’.

¹²⁸ Robinet, *Taoist Meditation*, 155.

¹²⁹ Vervoorn, *Men of the Cliffs*, 4.

Return

In the topography of mental reality, a land of bliss is accessible only in spiritual spontaneity. Going to this land is seen as ‘returning’ – a return towards the original state of existence. This redefinition of ‘return’ might have had a therapeutic effect on Su Shi, since, as an exile, he could not physically return home. Homesickness was, for him, an unaffordable malady.

癯人常念起
夫我豈忘歸
不敢夢故山
恐興墳墓悲

Even a paralysed person often thinks of rising –
how could I forget to think of return.
But I dare not dream of my homeland’s mountains,
lest I arouse the grief over my forefathers’ graves.¹³⁰

This poem was written shortly after he arrived in Hainan. He dreamt one night of his house at White Crane Peak in Huizhou, which he was forced to abandon soon after it was built. This, as he interpreted it, was because a dream of his Sichuan hometown would be too sad to bear. The comparison of himself to a paralysed person suggests a spell he could not break. A paralysed man is imprisoned by his physical handicap; a political exile is imprisoned in the vast landscape.

As Yoshikawa Kojirō has noticed, one of Su Shi’s favourite metaphors was “my life is like a sojourn only”.¹³¹ Instead of indulging in nostalgia and melancholy, Su decided to resign himself to the fluctuation of life and settle in the present moment so as to ensure that his true inner life “lie[s] in a continued resistance”.¹³² Therefore, on one hand, as life is a constant sojourn, ‘home’ is but an illusion; on the other hand, with ‘return’ redefined as a return to one’s authentic state, he is already ‘home’ wherever he might be. As a result, as early as in his time in Yangzhou, he attempted to regard the lack of career success as felicitous for such a return.¹³³ In his final exile, he further argues that misfortune facilitated his recognition of his “original face”:

瓶居本近危
甑墜知不完
夢求亡楚弓
笑解適越冠

The [broken] vase had always stayed close to peril;
a falling pot knows that it will not remain intact.
In dream I seek the bow lost in Chu;
laughingly I take off the ritual hat after going to Yue.

130 Su Shi, “He Tao ‘Huan jiuju’” 和陶還舊居, *SSSJ*, 41.2250–1.

131 Yoshikawa, *Sung Poetry*, 111.

132 *Ibid.*, 114.

133 See Su Shi, “He Tao ‘Yinjiu ershishou’”, no. 9, *SSSJ*, 35.1886.

忽然返自照
識我本來顏
歸路在脚底
殺潼失重關

All of a sudden, I come to see myself in the mirror,
and recognise in it my original face.
The road of return has always been under my feet;
the layered passes of Yao and Tong disappear.¹³⁴

In the “Jifu” 跡府 chapter of *Gongsun Longzi* 公孫龍子, it is said that the King of Chu once lost his precious bow while hunting. When his attendants volunteered to find it, the King stopped them and said, “When a man of Chu has lost his bow, a man of Chu will find it. What is the loss?”¹³⁵ This reference suggests that Su’s loss of rank was not a loss at all. Likewise, in a Zhuangzian parable, a merchant of Song came to Yue with many embroidered ritual hats, an item difficult to sell to the half-naked natives.¹³⁶ Laughingly taking off his own official hat, Su Shi shows his willingness to discard the accoutrements of culture, so that he could finally see his own true form. The “road of return” is not through the imposing mountain passes. Instead, his home is nowhere but in his innermost mind; thus, his feet have always been treading upon this “road of return”. The geographical distance between Hainan and his Sichuan hometown is translated into psychological space, easily covered in a single thought.

In this vision, the body becomes the lodge of mental activities such as dreams, meditation and spiritual roaming. It should be well maintained to facilitate these activities. Yet anxiety over mortality lurks behind Su Shi’s every thought of return, since death is its ultimate form. The following rhyme prose, “He Tao ‘Guiqulai xi ci’” 和陶歸去來兮辭,¹³⁷ matches Tao Qian’s earlier piece,¹³⁸ rhyme for rhyme, and rewrites Tao’s celebrated moment of homecoming, scene by scene. To a certain extent, it becomes an esoteric hymn on Daoist meditative practice.

[1] Zizhan is banished to live in Changhua [aka. Danzhou]. He matches Yuanming’s “Return!” and takes the Land of Nothingness as home. Even though he is beyond the seas, he is ever returning.

134 Su Shi, “He Tao ‘Dongfang you yi shi’”, *SSSJ*, 41.2266. The Yao and Tong passes (both in modern Shaanxi Province) are used here as synecdoche for mountains that are difficult to cross.

135 Wang Guan 王琯, *Gongsun Longzi xuanjie* 公孫龍子懸解 (Beijing: Zhonghua shuju, 1992), 1.34.

136 See the “Xiaoyaoyou” 逍遙遊 chapter in the *Zhuangzi*; *ZZJS*, 1.31.

137 Su Shi, *SSSJ*, 47.2560–1.

138 Tao Qian, “Guiqulai xi ci” 歸去來兮辭, *TYM*, 5.460–77.

子瞻謫居昌化，追和淵明《歸去來辭》，蓋以無何有之鄉爲家，雖在海外，未嘗不歸云爾。

This preface intimates that the true purpose of this composition is self-persuasion. Su shows resolution to settle in “the Land of Nothingness”. As discussed in Chapter Three, this land appears in a Zhuangzian parable, where a gigantic ailanthus tree could be valued exactly for being useless. “The Land of Nothingness” accommodates the one who does not belong. When the poet is attached to no place, everywhere can be “the Land of Nothingness”; Su transforms this into a pun on the material deprivation of Hainan. Yet, as Su argues, if his own settled mind is his true home, he is constantly returning.

[2] Return, return! I am freshly banished to the south, so how can I return? I lie amongst the expansion of the rivers and oceans, lamenting over the dolorous drums and horns announcing the hours. I left traces crouching in the mud, ever more deeply; gone is the time like flashes of lightning beyond my chase! I think of the southwest road to my home; dreaming is truly correct, but waking is not. I realise the inconstancy of this life, just like changing clothes at the shifts of seasons. But I shall not miss the ramie clothing of the summer when wearing winter fur, since I have rather gained big and lost small.

歸去來兮，吾方南遷安得歸。卧江海之瀕洞，弔鼓角之悽悲。迹泥蟠而愈深，時電往而莫追。懷西南之歸路，夢良是而覺非。悟此生之何常，猶寒暑之異衣。豈襲裘而念葛，蓋得犢而喪微。

The poem evokes Tao's famous invocation “Return, return!”, only to declare it beyond the capacity of an exile. To Tao Qian's “I realise today I am correct and in the past I was not” 覺今是而昨非,¹³⁹ Su responds that, for him, only dreaming is correct, since he can return home only in dreams, while his waking state is wrong, as reality forces him to face the inconstancy of life. He persuades himself to stop the vain nostalgia and settle in the present moment, arguing that his predicament is, in fact, a bargain.

[3] My return is truly facile, without galloping or rushing. In every simple action I am returning home. I get off my carriage and lock the gate. Though fences and walls have crumbled, the hall and chambers are still

139 See Tao Qian, “Guifulai xi ci”, *TYM*, 5.460.

intact. I fetch my Ale of Heaven and pour it into a hollow cup. I drink moonlit dew to cleanse my heart and dine upon the morning's rosy clouds to brighten my cheeks. The 'guest' and the 'host' become one and the same, so that the 'mother- and daughter-in-law' can live in peace. I realise there is no thief or robber, so I dismantle the gate and break the lock. I expand my round mirror to reflect the external world, which contains the myriad phenomena to be observed from the middle. As I dredge the deserted well to fetch fresh water in the morning, a hundred springs surge and brim overnight. I guard the extreme tranquillity¹⁴⁰ and let the energy rise by itself. At times it is like a leaping sparrow¹⁴¹ or a twirling giant salamander.¹⁴²

我歸甚易，匪馳匪奔。俯仰還家，下車闔門。藩垣雖闕，堂室故存。挹吾天醴，注之窪尊。飲月露以洗心，淩朝霞而眩顏。混客主以爲一，俾婦姑之相安。知盜竊之何有，乃扃門而折關。廓園鏡以外照，納萬象而中觀。治廢井以晨汲，滌百泉之夜還。守靜極以自作，時爵躍而鯢桓。

Tao Qian describes himself as riding a rushing carriage to return home, showing ecstasy and urgency. By contrast, Su Shi declares himself to have no such urge. Using a rhetorical device often found in Daoist literature, he transforms the physical space of a house to the metaphor of one's body. The borrowing is facile, since 'return' is also an essential term in Daoist alchemical literature; for instance, "returning to infancy"¹⁴³ suggests that human vitality is fully charged upon parturition and constantly discharges with every natural cycle of breath.¹⁴⁴

140 Reference to *Laozi* 16, "Attaining vacuity in its extremity,/guarding tranquillity firmly" 致虛極守靜篤; see Zhu Qianzhi, *Laozi jiaoshi*, 64.

141 *Jueyue* 爵躍 is a variant to *queyue* 雀躍. In the "Zaiyou" 在宥 chapter of the *Zhuangzi*, Yun 雲 (literally 'the cloud') in his roaming, met Hongmeng 鴻蒙 (literally 'the vast nebulousity'). The latter was patting his thigh and leaping around like a sparrow, about to roam too. Hongmeng's true wisdom, it transpires, is in hiding his wisdom. See *ZZJS*, 11.358.

142 In the "Yingdiwang" 應帝王 chapter of the *Zhuangzi*, Huzi 壺子 bewildered a shaman by appearing in various forms, and manipulated their physiognomy. He could do this because, as he explained, he was like the depths housing "twirling giant salamander", "flowing water" and "still water", among others. See *ZZJS*, 7.302.

143 As found in *Laozi* 55. "One who keeps the fullness of the life force,/is comparable to a newborn child" (含德之厚比於赤子); see Zhu Qianzhi, *Laozi jiaoshi*, 218; cf. Edmund Ryden trans., *Daodejing* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2008), 115.

144 For more discussions on the Daoist notion of "return" or "reverse" (*fan* 反), see Joseph Needham and Lu Gwei-Djen, *Spagyric Discovery and Invention: Physiological Alchemy*,

Cosmic sustenance provides pristine energy that recovers his physical and mental wellbeing. When he no longer makes a distinction between the external and the internal (the “guest” and the “host”), the conflicting forces within (the “mother- and daughter-in-law”) are harmonised. He is then capable of opening himself to the myriad forms, reflecting them inside as they truly are. His body is now a miniature of the cosmos. The mirror, as discussed in Chapter One, symbolises the tranquil, spontaneous mind which has omniscient cognitive capacity. The dredging from the deserted well symbolises the rediscovery of the inexhaustible fountain of energy that flows from within. In Daoist inner alchemy, because water is an essence that maintains life and is symbolic of the Way, maintaining a constant circulation of body fluid is crucial.¹⁴⁵ Water is also a symbol of simultaneous dynamism and tranquillity. By guarding his ultimate tranquillity, the poet finally transforms himself into a Zhuangzian figure who is an incarnation of primordial nebulosity (symbolised by Hongmeng 鴻蒙 who jumps joyously like a sparrow), or of the deepest depths (symbolised by Huzi 壺子 who hides like a giant salamander). The body becomes the physical embodiment of spontaneity.

[4] Return, return! Allow me to live through my days in this roaming voyage. My forefathers have left me this shabby hut – why should I abandon it and look elsewhere? Hainan and the central plains are truly equal; I bring myself along in comings and goings without worry. A Man at Odds gives me one wise word: there is no use for the Eight Diagrams or the Nine Laws! When a man is hungry, he needs food. When the river is crossed, discard the boat! Suddenly, the oxherd and the buffalo both disappear.¹⁴⁶ What remain are but tall trees and high hills. With alertness,

in *Science and Civilization in China*, pt.5 (Cambridge, UK: Cambridge University Press, 1983), 25; also 130–5, *passim*; Schipper Kristofer, *The Taoist Body*, trans. Karen C. Duval (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1993), 119; Robinet, *Taoist Meditation*, 140–1.

145 See, e.g., Robinet, *Taoist Meditation*, 90.

146 Referring to a phase in the Oxherding Pictures: a series of paintings with colophons which depict the process of an oxherd seeking a lost buffalo. These images, metaphoric for a Buddhist practitioner seeking his self-nature, have multiple versions from the tenth to the twelfth century, and differ in their number of phases. The earliest known version is by a certain Master Qingju 清居, with five phases (some tradition has it as “eight phases”); other versions are those by Zide 自得 (1097–1183) with six phases, and by Puming 普明 (before 1021) and Kuo’an 廓庵 (eleventh to the twelfth century), each with ten phases. Su Shi’s friend Foyin 佛印 (1032–1098) also seemed to have made a version with four phases. See Shi Tianhong 釋天宏, “Kuo’an ‘Shiniutu song’ kao: cong muniutu song tanqi” 廓庵《十牛圖頌》考：從牧牛圖頌談起, *Shijie zongjiao xuekan* 世界宗教學刊 (2011),

the six senses stay in abandonment; from one single root, I reverse the flow. Gazing afar at my old home, I long to rest. Yet how could I have rested already thrice midway?

歸去來兮，請終老於斯游。我先人之敝廬，復舍此而焉求？均海南與漢北，挈往來而無憂。畸人告予以一言，非八卦與九疇。方飢須糧，已濟無舟。忽人牛之皆喪，但喬木與高丘。警六用之無成，自一根之返流。望故家而求息，曷中道之三休。

This paragraph continues his self-persuasion. The “shabby hut” refers to his own body which he cannot abandon. He has learned to discard divination and human norms. And after he has passed the river, even “the boat” (or ‘skilful means’) that he relied upon to achieve enlightenment, should be abandoned. This state of truth is illustrated in Buddhist terms as the mutual oblivion of the subject and the object of seeking (the “oxherd” and the “buffalo”). This is the moment when one abandons the six sensory faculties and returns to the common origin of myriad things. Su fears, however, that he may fail to truly return, since his capacity is weak. Even though he knows that he shall not rest, he nevertheless has stopped to catch his breath, already thrice midway. His home remains fully in view, but beyond reach.

[5] Alas, let it be! My life is destined; my return timed. I in my original state neither go nor stay. Let me say: I will go wherever you go. How can I, in following the teachings of Zhuangzi, neglect to follow Anqi's suit! How can I, because crops planted in the drought will ultimately wither, refuse to water or to cultivate the seedlings! I have taken Yuanming's elegant abandonment as my example and have written hundreds of new poems in matching rhymes. I also write the pure prelude of “Return!” – I must be his reincarnation, no doubt!

17: 123–54. Given the multiple versions circulating at Su Shi's time, it is not clear which version he might have borne in mind. In both the Kuo'an and the Puming versions, “mutually forgotten” (*xiangwang* 相忘) refers to the eighth phase. But the Kuo'an version represents it with a full circle – symbol of *yuanxiang* 圓相 – with both the oxherd and the buffalo disappearing from the picture. Given that Su Shi described this phase as “[w]hat remain are but tall trees and high hills”, this was not the corresponding picture that he had in mind. Nor does it correspond to the Puming version, in which the eighth phase is depicted with the oxherd and the buffalo standing apart from each other (while the tenth phase is represented by a circle). An English discussion, translation and reproduction of the Puming pictures can be found in D.T. Suzuki, *Manual of Zen Buddhism* (London: Rider & Company, 1950), 127–44.

已矣乎，吾生有命歸有時，我初無行亦無留。駕言隨子聽所之，豈以師南華而廢從安期。謂湯稼之終枯，遂不溉而不耔。師淵明之雅放，和百篇之新詩。賦歸來之清引，我其後身蓋無疑。

In this last paragraph, Su Shi decides to reconcile himself with his limited capacity. If Zhuangzi represents the understanding of the ultimate philosophical truth – the equation of life and death, Scholar Anqi represents another esoteric truth – that a mortal can succeed in defeating death. As a principle of Daoist alchemy, death is a curable disease. Su Shi declares that he will follow both examples. He understands the ultimate destiny of decay, but, as the analogy borrowed from Ji Kang's 嵇康 (223–263) "Treatise on Nourishing Life" (Yangsheng lun 養生論) suggests, just like a farmer shall not give up watering his crops even in a time of drought, he should not give up nourishing his own life just because every effort ends in vain.¹⁴⁷ In the end, he claims to be Tao Qian's reincarnation; even though, when announcing their identity, Su has already modified the meaning of Tao's precedence. To 'return' in Su Shi's fashion, one must exercise oblivion and let oneself sink into a meditative, spontaneous mental state; one should also practise the Daoist art of longevity and immortality to maintain the "shabby hut" in which one is accidentally housed – ironically, to deter death, the ultimate 'return'.

Coda

Su Shi's emulation of Tao Qian held long-lasting significance. In the reception history of Tao Qian's poetry, his emulation was a crucial step which led to the gradual canonisation of Tao through the Song Dynasty. Indeed, many of Su Shi's admirers undertook writing similar poems 'matching Tao', a practice so widespread that it earned Chao Shuizhi's 晁說之 (1059–1129) mockery: "In just a single day, Tao Yuanmings suddenly swarmed in front of my eyes" 陶淵明紛然一日滿人目前矣.¹⁴⁸ Chao insisted that it was preposterous for lesser talents to write 'matching Tao', since Su Shi alone deserved to be Tao's match. As this reverent judgment shows, Su Shi's emulation had not only elevated the status of Tao Qian, but, at least for sympathetic readers, also made himself the unique equal of Tao Qian. Emulating Tao helped the formation of Su's 'mature

147 See Dai Mingyang 戴明揚, *Ji Kang ji jiaozhu* 嵇康集校注 (Beijing: Renmin wenxue chubanshe, 1962), 3.143–4.

148 See Hong Mai, *Rongzhai suibi*, 3.32.

style' (*laojing* 老境), characteristic for its deliberate limpidity, suppressed tension and understated aesthetics – all of which make its apparent simplicity belie rich subtlety. By stylistically 'returning' to Tao's purported simplicity, Su Shi declared himself to have fulfilled a trajectory of life 'returning' to its original spontaneity. His stylistic choice was hence, simultaneously, a moral choice.

For modern critics, Su's wistful declaration that he was Tao's reincarnation (*houshen* 後身) is also highly problematic. Taken at face value, it hinges upon multiple dubious assumptions: first, poetry is a mirror of the poet's true self; second, a later reader can fully grasp the precursor's truth through reading, despite the changed circumstances in which he lives; third, by writing in the precursor's style, he creates a similar literary persona, transforming himself into the faithful reproduction of the poetic persona that he emulates and recreates. Needless to say, the complete identification of the literary persona with the poet himself is a hazardous theoretical model, but it had its logical legitimacy in Su Shi's conceptual world, where poetry primarily had the expressionist value of conveying its author's moral truth.

Yet Su Shi's declaration also contains a tension that resists this straightforward reading; it begs to be taken with a grain of salt, since his model of stylistic 'return' is designed to fail. As Stephen Owen observed, since the Mid-Tang, authenticity and singularity had come to be seen as inseparable.¹⁴⁹ While Su Shi as Tao's reincarnation may 'inherit' Tao's style, an exact reproduction would belie the singularity of both poets. And, since Tao Qian's poetry was held as the paradigm of authenticity and spontaneity, emulating this paradigm necessarily required the emulator to be truly himself. As no two individuals are completely alike, Su Shi could declare himself to have become another 'Tao Qian' only by remaining stylistically different, which, as the aforementioned comments by Yuan Haowen and Ji Yun show, he did. A thorough imitation would lay bare the artificiality of the whole project. As observed in earlier chapters, stylistic spontaneity by necessity implies individuality.

All these paradoxes point to the element of self-persuasion underlying Su's effort. To be sure, the poetic persona of the 'simple' and 'natural' Tao Qian was already highly constructed and an idealised version of the historical person.¹⁵⁰ When Su Shi further transformed this rhetorically constructed image to make it even more simplified and symbolic, his ostentatious optimism purged those

149 Stephen Owen, *The End of Chinese 'Middle Ages': Essays in Mid-Tang Literary Culture* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1996), 20.

150 On the constructed nature of Tao's image, see Stephen Owen, "The Self's Perfect Mirror: Poetry as Autobiography", in *The Vitality of the Lyric Voice*, eds. Shuen-fu Lin and Stephen Owen (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1986), 71–102.

instances of anxiety or doubt that Tao Qian's poems occasionally betrayed. Tao Qian, in Su's narrow vision, lived a life predestined to become a metaphor – one that reflected Su's longing for an autonomous self, able to choose his path in life and to move beyond immediate or existential anxieties. Summarily put, Su elevated Tao's image to cult and mythical status. By wearing this mask he constructed, he exercised an imagined power over his own fate and sought freedom from persecution, deprivation and despair. In doing so, his alleged return into nature became, paradoxically, a retreat from nature, into a cultivated inner utopia of spontaneity.